

FAITH AND THEOLOGY

A Discursive Article

In Support of the Particular

On the Scandal of Particularity

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1 The Offense at Nazareth

The people who found Jesus of Nazareth hardest to believe in were the people who knew his street address. In the synagogue of his own town, the congregation heard him and asked the question that has never stopped being asked: “Is not this the carpenter’s son?” They knew his mother’s name. They could point to his relatives in the room. And the evangelist records the result without softening it: “And they were scandalized in his regard.”¹

Mark’s telling is blunter still. There the neighbors do not even grant the dignity of a patronymic: “Is not this the carpenter, the son of Mary, the brother of James, and Joseph, and Jude, and Simon? are not also his sisters here with us?”—a complete inventory of local connections, offered as a refutation. And Mark reports the consequence in a sentence that has troubled copyists and commentators ever since: “And he could not do any miracles there, only that he cured a few that were sick, laying his hands upon them.”² Whatever else that verse means, it records a place where the too-familiar particular became an obstacle instead of a door—and it is the first datum this article has to account for.

The scandal was not that he claimed too much for God. It was that he located God too precisely. A carpenter’s son, from this town, of that family—the offense lay in the definite articles. Nathanael, a few miles away and some months earlier, had compressed the whole difficulty into one question: “Can any thing of good come from Nazareth?”³

This reflex has a long intellectual pedigree, and it deserves to be stated with more respect than Nazareth gave it. In its serious form it runs roughly as follows. God, if the word means anything, means the absolute: unconditioned, unbounded, equally related to every time and place. But the Christian faith—and Israel’s faith before it—presents a God who chooses one nation among the nations, becomes one man in one province in one decade, and now communicates himself through particular washings and particular suppers performed with water from this tap and bread from that oven. Surely, the objection says, the particular is beneath the universal. A truth of geometry is nobler than a fact of geography. A God worth the name would deal in humanity, not in Galileans; in goodness, not in loaves. To tie the absolute to the particular looks like a category mistake at best and provincial self-flattery at worst. Theologians have long called the difficulty the scandal of particularity, and Scripture itself uses the same vocabulary: the crucified Messiah is “unto the Jews indeed a stumblingblock, and unto the Gentiles foolishness.”⁴

This article takes the objection seriously and argues that it is wrong—wrong not because the universal is unworthy of God, but because the objection misunderstands what universals are, what particulars are, and what kind of rescue human beings actually needed. The argument moves in an order that matters. It first lets the objectors speak at full strength and at length, because the objection is not a mood but a tradition with a documented history: it can be read in its own words across eighteen centuries, and reading it that way turns out to be part of answering it. It then examines the metaphysical premise hidden inside the complaint, because that premise can be tested by reason without appeal to revelation. Only afterward does it turn to what Israel, the Incarnation, and the sacraments claim, because those claims are not conclusions of philosophy and will not be presented as such. Philosophy can show that the objection fails; only the thing itself shows that the particular God acted. The distinction between those two kinds of showing is kept throughout, and the terminal appendices record, claim by claim, where each warrant lies.

2 The Objection at Full Strength

The complaint against particularity is old enough to have a documented lineage, and the lineage is worth walking, because the objection changes shape as it descends. In the second century it is a pagan philosopher’s ridicule of provincial vanity, backed by a considered doctrine of providence. In the seventeenth it is a metaphysical dissolution: a God identified with the order of nature cannot single anything out, so election is redescribed until it disappears. In the eighteenth it becomes an epistemological complaint about the wrong kind of truth, and then a positive program for a religion purged of history altogether. Each stage inherits the same premise and puts it to different work. This section states the objection in each of its major voices, quoting each at the strength its author intended, and identifies the premise they share. The answer begins in the next section, not here.

2.1 Celsus: the frogs in the marsh

The oldest surviving version of the objection is also the funniest. In the second century the pagan philosopher Celsus, whose attack on Christianity survives in the long quotations Origen made in order to answer it, compared Jews and Christians to “a flight of bats or to a swarm of ants issuing out of their nest, or to frogs holding council in a marsh, or to worms crawling together in the corner of a dunghill,” croaking to one another that “God shows and announces to us all things beforehand; and that, abandoning the whole world, and the regions of heaven, and this great earth, he becomes a citizen among us alone, and to us alone makes his intimations.”⁵ The passage continues, and the continuation is the part usually left out. The worms, Celsus says, also maintain “that all things have been made subject to us—earth, and water, and air, and stars—and that all things exist for our sake, and are ordained to be subject to us”; and that “now, since certain among us commit sin, God will come or will send his Son to consume the wicked with fire, that the rest of us may have eternal life with him.”

Strip the mockery and a real argument remains, and it has two premises rather than one. The first is cosmological: the universe is vast, humanity is one species on one planet, Israel was one small people within that species, and Jesus was one man within that people. Each narrowing, Celsus thinks, makes the claim less credible, because a rational God’s attention should be distributed like sunlight—evenly, over the whole. The second premise is his considered metaphysics of providence, and he states it flatly near the end of the same book: “All things, accordingly, were not made for man, any more than they were made for lions, or eagles, or dolphins, but that this world, as being God’s work, might be perfect and entire in all respects.” Hence “all things have been adjusted, not with reference to each other, but with regard to their bearing upon the whole. And God takes care of the whole, and (His) providence will never forsake it”—and, Celsus adds, God “is not angry on account of men any more than on account of apes or flies.”⁶

That is the objection’s philosophical core, and it is stronger than the frogs. Providence, on Celsus’s account, is a property of the system. It attends to the whole, and it attends to individuals only in the derivative way that a well-made machine attends to its parts. Once providence is defined so, particular address is not merely improbable; it is a category error, like asking which citizen a constitution is fond of.

2.2 Celsus again: the superintendents and the corner

Three further arguments in the surviving quotations deserve separate treatment, because between them they anticipate almost everything the objection would later become.

The first is Celsus’s theory of national religions, and it is startlingly modern. Each people, he argues, rightly keeps its ancestral rites, because “in all probability, the various quarters of the earth were from the beginning allotted to different superintending spirits, and were thus distributed among certain governing powers, and in this manner the administration of the world is carried on.” It follows that “whatever is done among each nation in this way would be rightly done, wherever it was agreeable to the wishes” of those powers, “while it would be an act of impiety to get rid of the institutions established from the beginning in the various places.”⁷ Celsus is not a relativist about truth; he is a conservative about cult. But the shape of the position is the one that returns, in a very different idiom, at the end of this article: many valid local paths, none of them the path, and a serene higher standpoint from which the locality of each is visible and the exclusive claim of any is bad manners.

From that platform he turns on Israel directly, and the tone hardens. If the Jews keep their own law, he allows, they are not to be blamed. But “if they pride themselves on it, as being possessed of superior wisdom, and keep aloof from intercourse with others,” the pride is unearned: their doctrine of heaven is Persian, their circumcision Egyptian and Colchian, their abstinence from swine’s flesh less rigorous than the Egyptians’ abstinences and less principled than the Pythagoreans’. “And I think,” Celsus continues, “that it makes no difference whether you call the highest being Zeus, or Zen, or Adonai, or Sabaoth, or Ammoon like the Egyptians, or Pappæus like the Scythians.” Then the sentence that states the election objection exactly: “It is not probable, however, that they enjoy God’s favour, or are loved by Him differently from others, or that angels were sent from heaven to them alone, as if they had had allotted to them ‘some region of the blessed,’ for we see both themselves and the country of which they were deemed worthy.”⁸

The second is the Incarnation’s, and it is the most exact statement of the scandal in the whole ancient record: “if God, like Jupiter in the comedy, should, on awaking from a lengthened slumber, desire to rescue the human race from evil, why did He send this Spirit of which you speak into one corner (of the earth)? He ought to have breathed it alike into many bodies, and have sent them out into all the world.” Celsus even supplies the theatrical comparison: the comic poet made Jupiter dispatch Mercury to the Athenians and Lacedæmonians for a laugh, and “do not you

think that you have made the Son of God more ridiculous in sending Him to the Jews?”⁹ Many bodies, everywhere, simultaneously: that is what a distributed God would have done. The demand is perfectly clear, and it is the demand this article will argue is incoherent, not merely unmet.

The third concerns descent as such, and it is the one the fourth century would have to answer. “What is the meaning of such a descent upon the part of God?”—asked as though any descent must be a diminishment. And then: “if he come down among men, he must undergo a change, and a change from good to evil, from virtue to vice, from happiness to misery, and from best to worst. Who, then, would make choice of such a change? It is the nature of a mortal, indeed, to undergo change and remoulding, but of an immortal to remain the same and unaltered.”¹⁰ That is the objection in its most philosophically serious dress: not that God would not stoop, but that God cannot, because to enter the particular is to be altered by it.

2.3 Spinoza: election dissolved into law

The modern Enlightenment gave the argument its philosophical dress. Spinoza’s *Theological-Political Treatise* devotes a chapter to the vocation of the Hebrews precisely in order to dissolve it, and the chapter’s method deserves as close a reading as its conclusions.

It opens not with history but with a definition of happiness: “Every man’s true happiness and blessedness consist solely in the enjoyment of what is good, not in the pride that he alone is enjoying it, to the exclusion of others.” Anyone who thinks himself more blessed because others lack what he has “is ignorant of true happiness and blessedness, and the joy which he feels is either childish or envious and malicious.”¹¹ From that premise the biblical texts are handled by anticipation. When Scripture says that the Lord chose Israel before other nations, that he is near to them and not to others, that to them alone he gave just laws, “it speaks only according to the understanding of its hearers,” who “knew not true blessedness.” Spinoza then applies a counterfactual test that does all the work: the Hebrews “would have been no less blessed if God had called all men equally to salvation, nor would God have been less present to them for being equally present to others; their laws would have been no less just if they had been ordained for all, and they themselves would have been no less wise.”

Notice the shape of that test. It asks whether anything of *value* would be lost if the particularity were removed—and value has already been defined as what can be possessed by everyone at once without diminution. On that definition the answer is guaranteed in advance. What the test cannot register is precisely what election claims to be: not a distributed good but an address, whose entire content is that it was made to someone.

The metaphysics is then stated without disguise. “By the help of God,” Spinoza writes, “I mean the fixed and unchangeable order of nature or the chain of natural events”; and “to say that everything happens according to natural laws, and to say that everything is ordained by the decree and ordinance of God, is the same thing.” Election follows as a corollary, and is thereby emptied: “since no one can do anything save by the predetermined order of nature, that is by God’s eternal ordinance and decree, it follows that no one can choose a plan of life for himself, or accomplish any work save by God’s vocation choosing him for the work or the plan of life in question, rather than any other.” Everyone is elect; therefore no one is. The word survives and the thing does not.

The historical conclusion is now merely bookkeeping. Whatever distinguished the Hebrews must have been something a legal order can confer, so it was political: “the Hebrew nation was not chosen by God in respect to its wisdom nor its tranquillity of mind, but in respect to its social organization and the good fortune with which it obtained supremacy and kept it so many years.” In wisdom and virtue “they were on a par with their fellows, and God was equally gracious to all”; their much-advertised election “consisted only in the temporal happiness and advantages of independent rule.” And the summary: “the individual Jew, taken apart from his social organization and government, possessed no gift of God above other men, and . . . there was no difference between Jew and Gentile.”

Notice what has happened, and what has not. Election has not been refuted by historical evidence; it has been ruled out in advance, because on Spinoza’s terms a God identical with universal law *cannot* single anything out. Choice requires a chooser, and a chooser who could have done otherwise. The denial of particular election is not a discovery about Israel. It is a corollary of a prior decision about what God is. Spinoza is admirably candid about this: the chapter runs from the definition of blessedness and the identification of God with nature to the reading of the texts, never the reverse.

It should be added, in fairness to him, that the chapter is not an exercise in contempt. Spinoza takes trouble to show from Scripture itself that God is gracious to all—Melchisedek a priest of the Most High before Abraham; Malachi’s

“from the rising of the sun, even until the going down of the same My Name shall be great among the Gentiles”; Job, “although a Gentile,” of all men most acceptable to God; Jonah’s God merciful to Nineveh. These are real texts, the next sections of this article will read several of them too, and on what they show there is no dispute. The disagreement is not over whether God’s care reaches everyone. It is over whether a care that reaches everyone must, for that reason, address no one.

2.4 Lessing: the ugly broad ditch

A century later, Gotthold Lessing gave the objection its epistemological form, and its most honest voice. The essay is short, occasional, and polemically restrained: written in 1777 during the *Fragmentenstreit* as an open letter to Johann Daniel Schumann, a director at Hannover, who had argued for Christianity from the evidential force of fulfilled prophecy and miracle. Lessing does not attack Christianity or dispute its worth. He attacks one inference—that one must believe because the Bible reports so many miracles and fulfilled prophecies—and he attacks it with a distinction so simple that its consequences took a century to absorb.

The distinction is between a miracle and a report of a miracle. Prophecies seen fulfilled and miracles witnessed are one thing; “the proof of the spirit and of power,” in the phrase from Origen that gives the essay its title, was available to those who stood there. But no one now living stood there. What we have are accounts, and accounts carry the reliability of ordinary historical testimony and no more.¹² From that the famous sentence follows: “Das ist: zufällige Geschichtswahrheiten können der Beweis von nothwendigen Vernunftwahrheiten nie werden”—that is, accidental truths of history can never become the proof of necessary truths of reason, as the sentence may be rendered. Between the contingent report and the eternal conclusion yawns what he called “der garstige breite Graben,” the ugly broad ditch, which he confessed himself unable to leap however earnestly he tried.¹³

The structure of the argument deserves to be laid out plainly, because it is often quoted as a mood when it is in fact a valid inference from stated premises. Take three claims. First, historical propositions are contingent: they might have been otherwise, and they are known, if at all, through testimony that could in principle be mistaken. Second, the truths religion is supposed to deliver—that God exists, that the soul is immortal, that the moral law binds—are necessary: they hold in every possible case, and a proposition of that strength cannot be entailed by any conjunction of contingent ones. Third, therefore no accumulation of historical evidence, however good, can establish them. The inference is sound. Nothing in this article disputes it. Everything in this article disputes the assumption, buried in the second premise, about what the cargo is.

For that is where the argument’s real load sits. Lessing’s ditch presupposes a definite picture of what religion is for: the delivery of necessary, universal truths to a reason that already, in principle, possesses them. If that is the cargo, then history really is the wrong vehicle. No pile of contingent facts adds up to a necessity, just as no number of thrown stones adds up to a proof in geometry. On this picture the particular is scaffolding at best: Jesus matters as an occasion for truths that could, in principle, have been reached without him, and an educated humanity will eventually thank the scaffolding and dismantle it.

Lessing himself stopped there, at the edge, describing a gap he could not cross. He did not propose the dismantling. Someone else did.

2.5 Kant: the particular as vehicle

Sixteen years after Lessing’s essay, Kant published *Die Religion innerhalb der Grenzen der bloßen Vernunft*, and what had been an honest impasse became a program. Where Lessing said that history cannot prove necessary truths, Kant undertook to show what religion looks like once one accepts that and reorganizes accordingly. The result is the most systematic version of the objection this article confronts, because it is not an attack on particularity at all. It is a generous plan for its retirement.

The premise is set by Kant’s moral theology. Since the idea of God arises with the consciousness of the moral law, and a divine will conceived purely by that standard admits only one God, “so by necessary consequence can there be room only for ONE religion, and that, too, purely moral.” Statutory divine commands may perhaps exist; but knowledge of them comes only by revelation, and revelation, “whether imparted to the mass publicly, or privately to single individuals for the purpose of being propagated by writing or tradition, would found a HISTORICAL but never a pure RATIONAL belief.”¹⁴ The consequence for particular religion follows at once, and Kant states it as

something close to arithmetic: statutory legislation “can only be looked upon as contingent, and as something that has not yet, and never can, be addressed to all, consequently, as what is not binding upon all mankind generally.”

That sentence is the whole objection in one line, and the sharpest form it ever takes. A historical revelation reaches only those it has reached. It arrives in a language, at a date, by a road; whole populations lived and died before the road was built and outside its reach. A God who binds all rational beings cannot, therefore, bind them by anything of that kind. Whatever is essential must be available to every rational being as such—which means available from reason, which means not from history.

Kant is precise about what remains for the historical, and precise about its expiry. Historical faith, resting on testimony and experience, “is particularly valid only . . . for those to whom the history has come,” and is held “with the consciousness of its contingency”; it may accordingly support “an ecclesiastical creed (whereof there may be several),” but only pure moral religion, founded throughout on the a priori, “can be recognised as necessary, and the single and alone belief characterizing the TRUE church.” A church may nevertheless bear that name while a historical belief attends religion “as its concomitant and introductory vehicle, provided always that this its latter character never be lost sight of, and that the church-creed contain within, the germ of a principle, whereby it is urged to a continual and more close approximation toward pure ethic and religion, until at length these last being attained, the other be superseded and dispensed with.”¹⁵

The image Kant uses for the relation is the one to keep. Saving faith, he says, must pervade every form of church-belief and “constitute the kernel of pure religion, gradually forth-forming itself, and bursting from the vehicular husk.” Particularity is the husk. It is not despised; it is credited with having carried the kernel, and it is expected to split and fall away. By the fourth book the verdict is formal: statutory faith, “confined to one particular race, and incapable of being represented as the catholic religion of our globe,” when “deemed essential to the worship of God, and made the supreme condition of the divine complacency, is a main delusion in religion, and the acting upon it a superstitious worship.”¹⁶

Set the voices side by side and the family resemblance is exact. Celsus says a distributed God would have breathed his Spirit into many bodies at once. Spinoza says a God identical with universal law can single nothing out. Lessing says contingent history cannot bear necessary weight. Kant says whatever binds all must be reachable by all, and history is not. Their conclusions differ—ridicule, dissolution, impasse, program—but each rests on a single load-bearing premise: that the universal is the natural home of the divine, and the particular a derogation from it. The abstract—law, essence, necessary truth—is noble; the concrete—this people, this man, this bread—is common, and at best instrumental. Test that premise, and the whole structure stands or falls with it.

3 What Actually Exists

3.1 No one has ever met a universal

Begin with an observation that requires no theology: everything that exists, exists as a particular. There is no such thing as *dog* trotting across a road; there are only individual dogs. There is no *humanity* that suffers or rejoices; there are only men and women, each with a fingerprint. Universals—dog, humanity, triangle, justice—are real objects of knowledge, and nothing here depends on denying their importance. But they do not walk about. In the classical account that this article adopts, a common nature has its concrete being only in individuals; taken apart from all individuals it exists, as Aquinas puts it, only “as existing in an intellect either human or Divine.”¹⁷

This gives the objection its first jolt. The objector says: the universal is nobler than the particular, so a God who deals in particulars is slumming. But nobler *as what*? As an object of contemplation, perhaps. As an agent, the universal is not merely humbler than the particular—it is nothing at all. Abstractions do not act. “Humanity” has never fed anyone; particular people have. Aquinas states the principle in passing while defining what a person is: rational substances “are not only made to act, like others; but . . . can act of themselves; for actions belong to singulars.”¹⁸ If God is to *do* anything in the world—create it, sustain it, rescue it—the doing will terminate in particulars, because there is nowhere else for action to land. A God who dealt only in universals would not be a more exalted God. He would be an idle one.

3.2 Abstraction is our limitation, not God's grandeur

The second jolt is sharper. Ask where abstraction comes from. In the Thomistic analysis of knowledge, it is the signature of a *finite* intellect. Human minds cannot grasp the singular in its full concreteness directly; we know material singulars, Aquinas argues, only indirectly, because “our intellect cannot know the singular in material things directly and primarily,” knowing instead what it abstracts—and “what is abstracted from individual matter is the universal.”¹⁹ We trade the singular for the general because the singular, in its inexhaustible detail, exceeds us. Abstraction is a coping mechanism. It is a glorious one—all science lives in it—but it is the strategy of a mind too small to hold the individual whole.

God's knowledge runs in exactly the opposite direction. Because God is the cause of things, “His knowledge extends as far as His causality extends”; and since his causality reaches not only forms but the very matter by which things are individuated, his knowledge reaches “to singular things, which are individualized by matter.”²⁰ Likewise providence: the causality of the first agent “extends to all being, not only as to constituent principles of species, but also as to the individualizing principles,” so that all things fall under providence “not only in general, but even in their own individual selves.”²¹

Here the objection quietly inverts. The philosopher who insists that God must relate to the world only through generalities—species, laws, averages—has not purified the idea of God. He has projected onto God the one intellectual limitation that is most distinctively ours. A God of universals only would be a God who knows the way a creature knows: by losing the individual in the type. The classical doctrine is stranger and better. Every sparrow is known singly, not as an instance of sparrowhood but as *this* sparrow, because the act by which it exists at all is an act of God bearing on it in particular.

Origen had already made the point against Celsus, and in almost these words. Where Celsus had held that God “takes care of the whole,” Origen answers that God takes care “not, as Celsus supposes, merely of the whole, but beyond the whole, in a special degree of every rational being.”²² The contrast is exact, and it is the hinge of the whole dispute. Celsus's providence is distributive: it reaches individuals through the system. Origen's, and afterward Aquinas's, is direct: it reaches the system through individuals, because individuals are what there are.

3.3 What makes this one this one

If particulars are what exist, it is worth asking what makes a particular the particular it is—and the classical answer bears directly on why the Incarnation had to happen to somebody.

The question is a real one, because natures do not individuate themselves. Human nature is what Socrates and Plato have in common; it cannot also be what distinguishes them, or it would be doing contradictory work at the same moment. Aquinas's answer, taken over from Aristotle and sharpened, is that in material things the principle of individuation is matter—not matter in general, which is as common as the nature, but this matter, marked out here and now. The formulation is given most cleanly in his early treatise *De ente et essentia*: matter is not the principle of individuation “taken in just any way, but only designated matter. And I call designated matter that which is considered under determinate dimensions.”²³ And then the sentence that matters most for everything this article goes on to say: in the definition of man, non-designated matter is what is posited, “for there is not posited in the definition of man *this* bone and *this* flesh, but bone and flesh absolutely.”

Read that slowly. The definition of man—the universal, the thing an intellect can hold—contains bone and flesh in general. It does not contain *this* bone. Nothing definable does. The concrete individual is precisely what falls outside every definition, which is why, as an objection in the *Summa* puts it and Aquinas partly concedes, “nothing singular can be subject to definition.”²⁴ The singular is not a deficient universal. It is what the universal is about, and it is always more than the universal manages to say.

The doctrine has a striking test case, and Aquinas applies it without flinching. If matter individuates, then beings without matter cannot be individuated within a species—so each angel must be its own species. He says exactly that: “such things as agree in species but differ in number, agree in form, but are distinguished materially. If, therefore, the angels be not composed of matter and form . . . it follows that it is impossible for two angels to be of one species; just as it would be impossible for there to be several whitenesses apart, or several humanities.”²⁵ Whatever one makes of the angelology, the method is instructive: the principle is pressed where it hurts, rather than quietly suspended.

It should be said that this was never the only account on offer. Duns Scotus, a generation later, held that the common nature is real and “indifferent” to existing in any number of individuals, but that in each individual it is contracted by a positive individuating principle proper to that individual—the *haecceitas*, the thisness—so that the humanity of Socrates is made individual by Socrates’s haecceity and the humanity of Plato by Plato’s.²⁶ The disagreement between the schools is real, is not settled in these pages, and does not need to be, because the two accounts converge on exactly what this article requires. On either view the individual is not a smudged copy of the species. On either view individuality is a positive perfection rather than a defect in the universal—for Scotus explicitly, since haecceity is something added rather than something lacking; for Aquinas by consequence, since designated matter is what a nature actually has when it actually is. The objector assumes that to be this one rather than that one is to be diminished by a limit. Both schools deny it.

3.4 The dignity of being someone

The classical tradition goes further, and the further step is the one the objection never anticipates. It does not merely defend the particular; it locates the summit of created being there.

Aquinas builds the case in stages. Individuality belongs in a special way to substances, because a substance is individuated by itself while accidents are individuated by their subject—this whiteness is called “this” because it is in this thing. Then, he says, “in a more special and perfect way, the particular and the individual are found in the rational substances which have dominion over their own actions.” And so such individuals receive a name of their own: person.²⁷ The conclusion, when it comes, is stated without hedging: “*Person* signifies what is most perfect in all nature—that is, a subsistent individual of a rational nature.”²⁸

That sentence should be set against the objection’s whole aesthetic. The objector’s scale of value runs upward from the concrete toward the abstract: this man, then humanity, then rational nature as such, then pure form, then God at the summit as the most general of all. The classical scale runs the other way at the decisive point. What is most perfect in all nature is not a nature. It is a subsistent individual—someone. Universality is not the direction of ascent; subsistence is.

The reason lies deeper still, in what the tradition says about existence itself. To be actual is not merely to instantiate a form; it is to have the act by which anything at all is. And that act, on the classical account, is what God gives—immediately, and continuously—to each thing that is. Aquinas draws the consequence in a passage that quietly dismantles the picture of a God who governs from a distance through general laws. God is in all things, he argues, not as part of their essence and not as an accident, but “as an agent is present to that upon which it works”; since “created being must be His proper effect,” and since God causes that effect “not only when they first begin to be, but as long as they are preserved in being,” God must be present to each thing for as long as it exists. Then the clinching step: “being is innermost in each thing and most fundamentally inherent in all things . . . Hence it must be that God is in all things, and innermost.”²⁹

The metaphysical distance between God and a general law could hardly be greater. A law abstracts from the individual: that is what makes it a law, and it is why a law can never say anyone’s name. The act of being does the opposite—it constitutes the individual as the individual it is. The objector’s proposal, that God relate to creatures as a statute relates to citizens, therefore does not exalt God above particular involvement. It substitutes, for the most intimate relation there could be, one of the most external available.

Two doctrines standing behind that paragraph are argued elsewhere rather than here, and it is worth saying so plainly rather than smuggling them in. That no finite nature accounts for its own existing, so that a creature’s being is received and participated rather than owned, is the burden of a companion study in this collection; so is the account of how perfections found in creatures may be predicated of their source analogically, neither univocally nor equivocally.³⁰ Neither is re-argued in these pages. What this section borrows from them is a single consequence: if creatures participate in existence rather than possessing it natively, then what a creature most fundamentally receives is not its species but its act of being—and that act is received by *this* thing. Participation is accordingly not a general relation obtaining between two categories. It is a relation each singular has, one at a time, to the one who is.

3.5 The universal cause is not a general thing

One confusion remains to be cleared, because the objection lives off it. “God is universal” is true in one sense and false in another. God is the universal *cause*: nothing exists that does not receive its being from him. But a universal cause is not a general *thing*, a widest category, a cosmic gas. Aquinas is blunt: God is not in any genus at all.³¹ He is not the most abstract item on the shelf; he is not on the shelf. The choice the objector offers—either an absolute God aloof from particulars, or a tribal god entangled in them—is therefore a false alternative resting on a class error. Precisely because God is not one being among beings, his relation to the particular is not competition for space within it. The universal cause is nearer to each singular thing than any general law could be, for the law abstracts from the individual and the cause gives the individual its very act of existing.

The same distinction disposes of Celsus’s dilemma about descent. He argued that if God comes down among men he must change, since to enter the particular is to be altered by it. That follows only if God is the sort of thing that occupies a position, so that arriving somewhere entails leaving somewhere else. Origen saw the point and made it first: the Word “does not give His place or vacate His own seat, so that one place should be empty of Him, and another which did not formerly contain Him be filled”—for “in speaking of His quitting one place and occupying another, we do not mean such expressions to be taken topically.”³²

None of this yet proves that God chose Abraham or took flesh from Mary. Metaphysics cannot deliver those claims, and this article will not pretend that it can. What the metaphysics does is demolish the veto. There is no rational principle by which the concrete is unworthy of God. If anything, the analysis points the other way: a God who knows and sustains every singular directly, and for whom being someone is the highest thing there is in creation, is a God for whom addressing *someone in particular* is not an embarrassment but the obvious idiom. Whether he has actually spoken is a question of fact, not of fittingness—and questions of fact are settled, if at all, in history. To history, then.

4 The Fewest of Any People

4.1 The narrowing

The Hebrew Scriptures do not treat particularity as an embarrassment to be minimized. They organize themselves around it, and they narrow deliberately, in stages, each stage more specific than the last.

It begins with a departure. Abram is ordered out of his own country with a promise whose last clause detonates the apparent favoritism: “in thee shall all the kindred of the earth be blessed.”³³ Then the covenant is formalized and the man is renamed for what the promise makes of him: “I will establish my covenant between me and thee, and between thy seed after thee in their generations, by a perpetual covenant.” The new name carries the outward direction inside itself—Abram becomes Abraham, “because I have made thee a father of many nations.”³⁴ The narrowing and the widening are announced together, in the same sentence, at the very moment the covenant is cut.

Then it narrows again, and the narrowing gets harder to like. Of Abraham’s sons the promise runs through one. Of Isaac’s twins it runs through the younger, and it is settled before either has done anything: “Two nations are in thy womb, and two peoples shall be divided out of thy womb, and one people shall overcome the other, and the elder shall serve the younger.”³⁵ Nothing in the text softens this. The choice precedes performance; it is not a reward. And when the promise reaches Jacob at Bethel, the same double movement returns exactly: “I am the Lord God of Abraham thy father, and the God of Isaac,” with the land promised to him and his seed—and then, immediately, “thou shalt spread abroad to the west, and to the east, and to the north, and to the south: and in thee and thy seed all the tribes of the earth shall be blessed.”³⁶ One family, one son, one grandson—and at each contraction the promise re-states its universal term. That is not the rhythm of a tribal charter. Tribal charters do not keep interrupting themselves to mention the neighbors.

4.2 Election announces its own smallness

If a people had invented its own election, the story would flatter the people. What Israel’s Scriptures actually say about the choice of Israel is almost perversely deflating. Moses tells the nation to its face: “Not because you surpass all nations in number, is the Lord joined unto you, and hath chosen you, for you are the fewest of any people: but because the Lord hath loved you, and hath kept his oath, which he swore to your fathers.”³⁷ The election of Israel is

presented as groundless in Israel—no superior size, wisdom, or virtue—and grounded entirely in a free love and a kept promise. Whatever this is, it is not tribal self-congratulation; tribal myths do not open by announcing that their tribe is the smallest and least impressive available.

Deuteronomy states the underlying logic even more starkly three chapters later, and there the universal and the particular are pressed into consecutive sentences. “Behold heaven is the Lord’s thy God, and the heaven of heaven, the earth and all things that are therein. And yet the Lord hath been closely joined to thy fathers, and loved them and chose their seed after them, that is to say, you, out of all nations.”³⁸ *And yet*: the text itself feels the tension the objector feels, and refuses to resolve it in either direction. The owner of the heaven of heavens is joined to this family. Deuteronomy does not treat that as a contradiction requiring repair. It treats it as the shape of the thing.

And the same chapter draws the practical conclusion that the objector predicts election cannot draw. Because the Lord is “the God of gods, and the Lord of lords . . . who accepteth no person nor taketh bribes,” who “doth judgment to the fatherless and the widow, loveth the stranger, and giveth him food and raiment”—therefore: “And do you therefore love strangers, because you also were strangers in the land of Egypt.”³⁹ The chosen people is commanded, in the same breath as its election, to love the unchosen—and the reason given is not that the stranger is also elect, but that Israel remembers being one. Election, in this text, produces hospitality rather than contempt, and produces it precisely from the memory of having been outside.

4.3 The prophets: universality by way of the particular

The prophets keep the pattern and sharpen it into paradox.

Amos performs the most startling operation. He takes the exodus—the constitutive event, the thing that makes Israel Israel—and relativizes it in a rhetorical question: “Are not you as the children of the Ethiopians unto me, O children of Israel, saith the Lord? did not I bring up Israel, out of the land of Egypt: and the Philistines out of Cappadocia, and the Syrians out of Cyrene?”⁴⁰ God, the prophet says, has been running other nations’ exoduses too. And the conclusion he draws from this is not that Israel is therefore ordinary, but that Israel is therefore more accountable: the next verse turns immediately to judgment—“Behold the eyes of the Lord God are upon the sinful kingdom, and I will destroy it from the face of the earth”—qualified at once by the promise that the house of Jacob will not be utterly destroyed.⁴¹ That is the precise inversion of tribal religion. A tribal god’s special relation exempts; this one’s incriminates.

Isaiah states the positive form of the logic, and states it about a servant who is addressed with almost embarrassing particularity: “The Lord hath called me from the womb, from the bowels of my mother he hath been mindful of my name.” Called from the womb, known by name, hidden in a quiver like a chosen arrow—and then the commission arrives and blows the frame apart: “It is a small thing that thou shouldst be my servant to raise up the tribes of Jacob . . . Behold, I have given thee to be the light of the Gentiles, that thou mayst be my salvation even to the farthest part of the earth.”⁴² “A small thing”: the restoration of Israel alone would be too little a commission. The particular vocation is described as insufficiently ambitious until it reaches the ends of the earth.

Election, in the Bible’s own grammar, is a means of universality, not its rival. One is chosen *for* the many. The particular is where the blessing enters; the world is where it is going.

4.4 Answering Spinoza: address must land somewhere

Spinoza’s God, being identical with universal law, was equally gracious to all in the only way a law can be: by applying to all. But notice what such equal graciousness can never do. It can never say anyone’s name. A law addresses no one; it merely holds. If God’s dealing with the world were exhausted by generality, then whatever else religion could be, it could not be an encounter—and the biblical claim is precisely that it is one.

Once encounter is on the table, particularity follows by necessity, not by scandal. Speech must be in some language; arrival must be at some door. A covenant with everyone-in-general, contracted nowhere, at no date, in no tongue, is not a wider covenant but no covenant. The choice of *somewhere* is the price of anything actually happening.

Spinoza’s counterfactual test can now be answered on its own terms. He asked whether the Hebrews would have been less blessed had God called all men equally, and answered no—from which he concluded that the particularity added nothing. But run the test on any address whatever and see what it proves. Would this letter be less valuable

if identical letters had been sent to everyone? In one sense, no: the information is the same. In another sense the question destroys its object, because a letter sent to everyone is not a letter, and what the recipient valued was never the information. Spinoza's test measures the transferable content of election and finds it fully transferable, which is true and beside the point, because the claim was never that Israel possessed a commodity others lacked. The claim was that Israel was addressed. Address is exactly the sort of good that the test cannot see, since the test's first move is to ask what would survive being distributed—and address does not survive being distributed. It is not scarce; it is particular. Those are different things, and the whole objection depends on conflating them.

There is a second point, and it is the more serious. Spinoza's method was to read the election texts as accommodations to a childish audience: Scripture "speaks only according to the understanding of its hearers." The principle is not absurd, and the tradition has its own versions of it. But as Spinoza deploys it, it is unfalsifiable. Any text asserting particular divine choice can be reassigned to the audience's limitations; no text could ever count against the thesis, because the thesis controls in advance what a text is allowed to mean. That is a considerable price to pay, and it is worth noting who pays it. The texts themselves, as we have just seen, are not naive about the difficulty. They say "the heaven of heaven" is God's, *and yet* he chose these people. They say God brought up the Philistines too. They say the servant's commission to Israel alone would be too small a thing. A hypothesis whose explanation of these passages is that their authors had not noticed the problem is a hypothesis explaining texts that raise the problem themselves.

The objector hears "God chose Israel" as "God neglected everyone else"; the texts say the opposite—the God who chose Israel is the God already governing Philistine and Syrian migrations, and the choice is the appointed route by which "all the kindred of the earth" are blessed. What Spinoza's dissolution of election preserves is God's impartiality. What it forfeits is God's ability to love anyone in particular—and a love of everyone that cannot be a love of anyone is suspiciously like the universal benevolence of a man who is kind to Humanity and cold to his neighbors.

It must be said plainly that this argument establishes the coherence of election, not the fact of it. That history contains many claimed elections, and that this one begins somewhere, does not by itself certify that this one is real; that certification belongs to the whole long argument between Israel's God and history, which this article cannot conduct. But the standing complaint—that a choosing God is beneath the dignity of the absolute—has by now lost both its supports. Metaphysically, the absolute is not a general law but the cause of every singular. Scripturally, the choosing is ordered to the whole world and announces its own gratuity. What remains of the scandal is only this: that the promise kept narrowing—one people, one tribe, one house, one woman—until it became a single person. And there the objection stops being an argument about nations and becomes an argument about a body.

5 The Word in a Part

5.1 A dated God

Christianity did not ease the scandal of particularity; it consummated it. "And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us."⁴³ Paul gives the event a timestamp—"when the fulness of the time was come, God sent his Son, made of a woman, made under the law"—and Luke gives it a bureaucratic setting, a tax census, "a decree from Caesar Augustus," an enrollment "first made by Cyrenus, the governor of Syria."⁴⁴ Luke does it a second time, and more elaborately, when John the Baptist appears: "in the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar, Pontius Pilate being governor of Judea, and Herod being tetrarch of Galilee, and Philip his brother tetrarch of Iturea . . . under the high priests Annas and Caiaphas."⁴⁵ Six office-holders are named before the sentence reaches its subject. The creeds would later fix the other end of the life with a governor's name: suffered under Pontius Pilate. No founding documents of any movement have ever been less interested in escaping contingency. Where Lessing saw accidental truths of history as religion's embarrassment, the evangelists nail their claim to the calendar as if daring the reader to check.

5.2 The genealogies as theology

The habit reaches its extreme in the two lists that modern readers skip. Matthew opens his Gospel not with a doctrine but with a pedigree—"The book of the generation of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham"—and then forty-odd names of begetting, most of them men no one remembers.⁴⁶ A genealogy is the least universal literary form there is. It is a claim of descent, unrepeatably, unshareable, and falsifiable in principle. Beginning a Gospel with one

is a deliberate act: it says that what follows is not a philosophy that happens to have arisen in Palestine but the terminus of a particular family's history.

Two features of Matthew's list do argumentative work. The first is its direction: it runs backward to Abraham and stops there, anchoring Jesus inside the covenant traced in the previous section. The second is whom it declines to omit. Four women appear in a patrilineal register that had no formal need of them, and all four are irregular by the standards of the genre—Thamar, Rahab, Ruth the Moabite, and, unnamed, “her that had been the wife of Urias.” The list also carries Manasses, and it marks the deportation to Babylon twice, as a hinge.⁴⁷ The line is not laundered. Whatever else Matthew is doing, he is not constructing a myth of pure origin; he is asserting that the Word entered a real family with a real record, the kind that has a Moabite in it and a king's worst night.

Luke's list runs the other way, and the difference is the point. He places it not at the beginning but after the baptism, and he traces the descent backward past Abraham, past Noah, to the last two names on the list: “who was of Adam, who was of God.”⁴⁸ Matthew's genealogy roots Jesus in Israel; Luke's roots him in humanity and terminates in God. Between them the two lists state, in the most concrete idiom available to an ancient writer, the exact structure this article has been describing: the particular entered at one determinate point in one determinate family, and reaching backward through that point one arrives at everyone.

5.3 The Word in a body

The claim, note carefully, is not the modest one that a great teacher arose in Galilee. It is that the eternal Word—the one through whom, the tradition had just finished saying, every singular thing receives being—assumed a particular human nature and lived a bounded human life. The fourth-century writers who defended this saw exactly where the pressure lay, because their pagan critics pressed it. Athanasius, answering Greeks who scoffed at the Word appearing in a body, refuses to blink at the metaphysics. The Word who took “a body, and that of no different sort from ours” was not thereby diminished or contained: “He was not, as might be imagined, circumscribed in the body, nor, while present in the body, was He absent elsewhere.”⁴⁹ The Incarnation is not God squeezing into a part and vacating the whole. It is the one who fills the whole making himself knowable in a part.

Athanasius then turns the objectors' own cosmology against them. You grant, he says, that the Word pervades the universe; you should then “not think it absurd that a single human body also should receive movement and light from Him”—for a man who admits the mind works in the whole body but balks at its working in the toe “would be thought foolish.” And to the demand for a grander instrument—“Why then did He not appear by means of other and nobler parts of creation, and use some nobler instrument, as the sun, or moon, or stars, or fire, or air, instead of man merely?”—he answers with the sentence that collapses the whole aesthetic of the objection: “the Lord came not to make a display, but to heal and teach those who were suffering.”⁵⁰ A sun-god would have been a spectacle. Spectacles are for impressing the healthy. The sick need someone to arrive, at their scale, through their door. The choice of the small instrument is not a concession to human weakness incidental to the mission; it *is* the mission's shape, because what had gone wrong—among all creatures, Athanasius notes, only man had gone wrong—was small, local, and fleshly, and the repair had to go where the wound was.

5.4 Answering the corner

Celsus had posed the sharpest form of the demand: why one corner of the earth, when he ought to have breathed his Spirit “alike into many bodies, and have sent them out into all the world”? Origen's answer is worth having in full, because it does something the objection did not anticipate.

He grants the observation and denies its force. The advent “apparently to one corner (of the earth) was founded on good reasons, since it was necessary that He who was the subject of prophecy should make His appearance among those who had become acquainted with the doctrine of one God, and who perused the writings of His prophets”—and, crucially, that he should come “at a time when the Word was about to be diffused from one corner over the whole world.” Then the sentence that answers the arithmetic: “there was no need that there should everywhere exist many bodies, and many spirits like Jesus, in order that the whole world of men might be enlightened by the Word of God. For the one Word was enough, having arisen as the Sun of righteousness, to send forth from Judea His coming rays into the soul of all who were willing to receive Him.”⁵¹ Two claims are packed there, and both matter. The first is that the location was not arbitrary but prepared—an argument from fittingness, offered retrospectively, in the mode this article has been careful to keep. The second is the answer to the objection's implicit mathematics:

many simultaneous incarnations would not have been a greater generosity, because one is sufficient for a thing that propagates. Celsus imagined a divine gift distributed like rations, where more sites of delivery mean more delivered. Origen's counter-image is a sunrise, which does not need to happen in every valley separately.

The objector may of course reject the counter-image; the argument does not turn on the metaphor. What the exchange establishes is that the demand for many bodies rested on an unexamined premise—that reaching everyone requires being everywhere at once—and that the premise is false wherever what is given can be handed on. Whether it was in fact handed on is a historical question, and one on which the objector and the believer can consult the same evidence.

5.5 Why the flesh had to be someone's

Irenaeus, a century before Athanasius, had already seen that the rescue fails unless the particularity is real all the way down. Against teachers for whom Christ's flesh was celestial or apparent, he asks the unanswerable housekeeping question about the Virgin: "why did He come down into her if He were to take nothing of her?" If Christ did not receive "the substance of flesh from a human being," the exchange at the heart of the Gospel never occurs; for the Word of God "did, through His transcendent love, become what we are, that He might bring us to be even what He is Himself."⁵² A generic incarnation—God assuming "humanity" in the abstract—would touch no one, because no one is humanity in the abstract.

Aquinas later gave that instinct its technical form, and it is worth pausing on, because it answers the objector's "why one man?" with unexpected precision. Could the Word have assumed human nature "abstracted from all individuals"? No—outside individuals, human nature has no concrete being to assume; apart from them it exists only in an intellect.⁵³ Could he then have assumed it in *all* individuals at once? Again no: "It was unfitting for human nature to be assumed by the Word in all its supposita," for that would abolish the many persons the nature exists to multiply, and would empty the Head-members relation by which the one Christ is "the First-born of many brethren."⁵⁴ The alternatives to the scandal, in other words, are not nobler incarnations; they are non-events. If God is to become man at all, God becomes *a* man. The particularity that offends is simply what reality costs.

Here the metaphysics of the earlier section pays its debt. Recall Aquinas's remark that the definition of man contains bone and flesh absolutely, and not *this* bone and *this* flesh. What the definition cannot contain is exactly what the Incarnation claims to have assumed. There is no such thing as taking on flesh in general, for the same reason there is no such thing as owning money in general: the assumption terminates in designated matter or it terminates in nothing. Celsus's alternative—many bodies everywhere—does not escape this; it multiplies it, and buys nothing, since each of the many would have been as particular as the one. The objection to particularity is not, on inspection, an objection to a choice God made. It is an objection to there being individuals at all.

And why should he become man at all? Here Aquinas argues fittingness, not necessity, and the distinction is part of the article's method: after the fact, one can see how the event befits God; no one could have deduced it beforehand. It belongs to the very nature of the good to communicate itself—*pertinet autem ad rationem boni ut se aliis communicet*—and so it befits the highest good to communicate itself in the highest way, which occurs, Aquinas says quoting Augustine, when God so joins created nature to himself "that one Person is made up of these three—the Word, a soul and flesh."⁵⁵ The maximal self-gift of the universal Good is not a universal broadcast. It is a union so close that the gift has a face.

5.6 The ditch from the other side

Now return to Lessing. His ditch is real, given his cargo: contingent facts can never total up to necessary truths. But the Gospel never proposed to carry that cargo. It does not offer history as a proof of geometry-like theses; it claims that the decisive good is itself an event—that "all other historical events happen once, and then they pass away, swallowed up in the past," as the Catechism will put the contrast, while this one, uniquely, does not.⁵⁶ What human beings needed saving from was never their ignorance of necessary truths, which the philosophers were already supplying at market rates. It was a condition: mortality, guilt, the unraveling of concrete lives in concrete bodies. A condition is not refuted; it is healed. And healing, unlike proof, is necessarily particular—it happens to patients, one by one, or not at all. Lessing standing at his ditch resembles a man who, informed that the doctor has arrived, objects that no visit, being a mere event, can demonstrate the axioms of medicine. The objection is exact and beside the point. The doctor has not come to demonstrate. "The Lord came not to make a display, but to heal."

The same reply, pressed one step further, meets Kant. His premise was that whatever binds all rational beings must be reachable by all as such, and that a historical revelation, reaching only those to whom the history has come, therefore cannot be essential. Grant the premise about *obligations* and the conclusion follows for obligations. But it does not follow for gifts, and the two are not governed by the same rule. A law that binds only those who happen to have heard of it is defective as a law; a rescue that reaches only those it has so far reached is not thereby defective as a rescue—it is unfinished, which is a different complaint and has a different remedy, namely going. That is why the same documents that assert the particularity assert the mission in the next breath, and why the objection from limited reach has, throughout Christian history, produced not an argument but a travel schedule.

Two things follow, and it is worth separating them. The first is that Kant’s argument, if sound, would prove far more than he wanted. Any good that must be received from another and cannot be generated from within—being told something, being forgiven by the person one wronged, being loved—fails his test in exactly the way revelation does, since none of them is available to every rational being as such. A criterion that disqualifies revelation on that ground disqualifies most of what makes a life good. The second is that his proposal is self-undermining in its own terms. The kernel is supposed to burst from the vehicular husk; but the moral religion Kant describes as the kernel was, historically, extracted from the husk—he is refining a tradition he received, in a vocabulary he inherited, with a moral seriousness formed by the very statutory religion he expects to be dispensed with. Vehicles that constitute their cargo are not vehicles. This is not a refutation of his ethics, and it is not offered as one. It is a reason to doubt the metaphor.

The last irony the objection must digest is that this most particular of events is the ground of the most universal claim ever made about human beings. The Council’s sentence is famous: “For by His incarnation the Son of God has united Himself in some fashion with every man.” He worked with human hands, thought with a human mind, loved with a human heart⁵⁷—and precisely by being irrevocably one of us, he is related to all of us, as no abstraction ever related to anyone. Universality was not sacrificed at Bethlehem. It was funded there. To the Greeks, foolishness; but the argument of these pages has been that “the foolishness of God is wiser than men.”⁵⁸

6 This Water, This Bread

6.1 The particularity did not retire at the Ascension

A tempting compromise would concede everything so far and then quietly re-abstract the result: granted, God acted particularly *then*; but now the Incarnation survives as a truth to be believed, an example to be admired—portable, general, safely conceptual. That is, in effect, Kant’s proposal with the dates filled in: the husk has done its work and may now split. The Church’s sacramental teaching exists to block precisely that retreat. Leo the Great, preaching on the Ascension, states the principle in a single clause: “that which till then was visible of our Redeemer was changed into a sacramental presence.”⁵⁹ The visible body departs; the mode of presence changes; the particularity does not. What replaces the carpenter’s hands is not an idea but a set of instituted, perceptible acts—washing, anointing, the giving of bread and the cup—each as concrete, as datable, as located as Nazareth.

The Catechism explains why this is not a lapse back into magic but the continuation of the same divine style. The sacraments are “perceptible signs (words and actions) accessible to our human nature,” by which the risen Christ, seated at the Father’s right hand, now acts to communicate the grace they signify. And they are possible because the Paschal event is unlike every other event: all others “happen once, and then they pass away, swallowed up in the past,” but the Paschal mystery of Christ “cannot remain only in the past,” since in its death itself was destroyed and everything Christ did and suffered participates in divine eternity.⁶⁰ Lessing’s ditch was dug on the assumption that a past event can reach the present only by report, dwindling as testimony dwindles. The sacramental economy is the claim that this one event reaches the present by *presence*—that the ditch is crossed, not by our leap backward, but by the event’s own refusal to recede.

6.2 Why signs suit us

Aquinas’s defense of sensible signs completes the pattern this article has been tracing since the discussion of abstraction, and it is worth taking in its full structure rather than in a single line.

He begins from what a sign is and whom signs are for: “Signs are given to men, to whom it is proper to discover the unknown by means of the known.”⁶¹ Then the governing principle: divine wisdom “provides for each thing according to its mode,” and it is the human mode—the point was established about knowers, and returns here about worshipers—“to acquire knowledge of the intelligible from the sensible.” Hence sacraments are sensible things; and not sensible things in general, but “those things which are determined by Divine institution,” since “it is not for anyone to determine that which is in the power of another,” and sanctification is in God’s power, not ours.⁶²

That last point deserves more weight than it usually gets. The signs are not merely sensible; they are *determined*. Water, not any cleansing liquid; bread and wine, not any meal. A religion of natural symbolism would let each culture select its own emblems, which is precisely what the pluralist reading of religion expects and what Celsus’s superintending spirits would have arranged. The instituted economy does the opposite: it fixes the particulars, and it fixes them by an act of choice on the giver’s side. This is the same grammar as election, transposed from peoples to elements.

Aquinas then adds an argument that ties the sacraments directly to the Incarnation, and it is the keystone of this whole section. Why must words be added to the sensible element? Because the sacraments must have “a certain conformity” to the cause of sanctification, “which is the Word incarnate . . . in that the word is joined to the sensible sign, just as in the mystery of Incarnation the Word of God is united to sensible flesh.”⁶³ The structure of a sacrament, on this account, is not merely convenient; it is a deliberate reprise. The pattern of word-joined-to-flesh, having happened once at Nazareth, is made repeatable at every font. If one finds the Incarnation’s particularity offensive, one will find the sacraments offensive for exactly the same reason, and consistently so. The tradition, for its part, treats the resemblance as an argument in favor.

The necessity of such signs, Aquinas argues in the following question, has three roots, and the second is the one this article most needs. The first is the condition of human nature, which “has to be led by things corporeal and sensible to things spiritual and intelligible.” The second is the state of fallen man, “who in sinning subjected himself by his affections to corporeal things”—and here the principle is medical: “the healing remedy should be given to a man so as to reach the part affected by disease.”⁶⁴ That is Athanasius’s argument about the small instrument, restated for the age after the Ascension. The repair goes where the wound is; the wound was in the flesh; therefore the repair is applied through flesh. A purely spiritual religion—all interiority, no matter—would be fitted for angels, and its persistent attraction for us is one more instance of the flight into abstraction this article has been resisting throughout: the preference for a God who makes no landings. The actual economy is humbler and more invasive. Grace comes to a creature of flesh through flesh: through water that is wet, bread that is bread, words said aloud by one particular minister to one particular person with a name.

6.3 Signs of the covenant

The Catechism sets out the same economy historically, and the sequence it describes is the article’s argument in liturgical form. Sacramental signs, it says, have a meaning “rooted in the work of creation and in human culture, specified by the events of the Old Covenant and fully revealed in the person and work of Christ.” Three strata, each more particular than the last.

The first stratum is universal and natural. “As a being at once body and spirit, man expresses and perceives spiritual realities through physical signs and symbols”; and God “speaks to man through the visible creation,” in which “light and darkness, wind and fire, water and earth, the tree and its fruit speak of God and symbolize both his greatness and his nearness.” The Catechism then says something the objector should notice, since it concedes a great deal of what the pluralist wants: “The great religions of mankind witness, often impressively, to this cosmic and symbolic meaning of religious rites.”⁶⁵

The second stratum is where particularity enters, and the Catechism names it exactly: “Signs of the covenant.” The chosen people “received from God distinctive signs and symbols that marked its liturgical life. These are no longer solely celebrations of cosmic cycles and social gestures, but signs of the covenant, symbols of God’s mighty deeds for his people”—circumcision, the anointing of kings and priests, the laying on of hands, sacrifices, “and above all the Passover.”⁶⁶ That is the decisive transition, and it is the same transition Deuteronomy made. A cosmic symbol says something true about God in general; a sign of the covenant says something that happened. Water can mean cleansing anywhere; a Passover means a night.

The third stratum narrows again to a person: signs “taken up by Christ,” who gives new meaning to the deeds and signs of the Old Covenant, “for he himself is the meaning of all these signs.” And then the sacramental signs proper,

through which, since Pentecost, the Spirit “carries on the work of sanctification”—signs which “do not abolish but purify and integrate all the richness of the signs and symbols of the cosmos and of social life.”⁶⁷ Cosmos, covenant, Christ, Church: at each stage the sign becomes more particular and the reach becomes wider, which is the pattern this article has been documenting since Abraham.

6.4 This bread

The Eucharist is where the pattern reaches its limit, and where the objection, if it is going to break, breaks.

Aquinas’s account of why Christ’s body is present in the sacrament turns on the same premise as the Incarnation. It “belongs to Christ’s love, out of which for our salvation He assumed a true body of our nature”; and because friendship wants presence, “meanwhile in our pilgrimage He does not deprive us of His bodily presence; but unites us with Himself in this sacrament through the truth of His body and blood.”⁶⁸ The Eucharist, on this account, is not a departure from the logic of the Incarnation but its continuation under changed conditions: the same love that would not save humanity at a distance will not accompany it at a distance either.

And then a corollary that inverts the objection’s arithmetic completely. Christ is present in the sacrament after the manner of substance, not of dimensive quantity; and since “the whole nature of a substance is under every part of the dimensions under which it is contained”—as the whole nature of bread is under every part of the bread—“it is manifest that the entire Christ is under every part of the species of the bread, even while the host remains entire, and not merely when it is broken.”⁶⁹ Celsus wanted many bodies so that the gift would reach many places. The doctrine he was mocking says that the whole is in each part—which is precisely what a distributed rationing of the divine could never manage, since rations divide. Whatever one makes of the metaphysics, the shape of the claim is the exact contrary of the one the objection assumed it was attacking. Particularity here is not the fragment left over after the whole has been divided. It is the mode in which the whole is had.

6.5 The Church’s own particularity

The same grammar governs the community that results, and the New Testament states it in a formula that reads like a deliberate provocation to universalism: “One body and one Spirit; as you are called in one hope of your calling. One Lord, one faith, one baptism. One God and Father of all, who is above all, and through all, and in us all.”⁷⁰ Count the singulars: one body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism. Then the sentence’s destination: “one God and Father of all.” The universality is stated at the end, and everything leading to it is a determinate singular. The passage does not treat this as a tension to be managed; it treats the series as the way the universal claim is made.

Baptism in particular is the hardest case for the objection and the clearest instance of the pattern. It is not a disposition, an insight, or an allegiance held inwardly. It is an act, performed at a place, by someone, on someone, with water, once. There is no general baptism; there are only baptisms. And the offer is universal in exactly the way the earlier sections described: not by being abstract, but by being repeatable.

For the recipient, this particularity is not a limit on assurance but its instrument. An abstract salvation must be verified abstractly—by introspection, by the quality of one’s feelings, a notoriously bottomless audit. A sacrament happens or it does not. It happened to *you*, on a date, at a font one can drive to. The definite articles that scandalized Nazareth turn out, at the receiving end, to be the whole comfort: not humanity in general invited to a possible mercy, but this person, washed on this morning, in this parish, by name.

The universal reach that the objector feared was being lost is, once again, achieved rather than abandoned. Precisely because the sacramental acts are small, repeatable, and material, they can be performed anywhere humans are—in cathedrals and prison cells, over any water, in every language—until the particular address has been multiplied toward every particular person. A universal offer that remained abstract would reach no one; the concrete sign, endlessly reiterated, is how the once-for-all event goes out “even to the farthest part of the earth.”

7 The Objection in Its Newest Form

7.1 From ridicule to courtesy

The objection that began as mockery now arrives as good manners, and that is a genuine change, not a rhetorical one. Nobody in a contemporary university compares Christians to frogs. What is said instead is gentler, more informed, and considerably harder to answer: that the world's religious traditions are so many culturally shaped responses to one ultimate Reality, that each is a valid path, and that the claim of any one of them to be *the* decisive act of God is a provincialism that better acquaintance dissolves. The argument's premises have changed—they are now empirical and epistemological rather than cosmological—but the conclusion is Celsus's: God does not do particular.

It is worth saying at once why this is the strongest form the objection has ever taken. Celsus knew of a handful of religions and despised most of them. Spinoza reasoned from a definition. Kant reasoned from a criterion. The contemporary pluralist reasons from acquaintance—from the fact, unavailable to the earlier objectors in anything like its present detail, that hundreds of millions of people have lived recognizably holy lives inside traditions that make claims incompatible with the Christian one. That is a datum, not a theory, and any answer that pretends not to feel its weight is not worth giving.

7.2 The pluralist hypothesis stated

The most influential formulation is John Hick's, and it should be stated in its own terms before it is examined. Hick did not deny that the traditions conflict; he held, on the contrary, that "the differences of belief between (and within) the traditions are legion," and discussed those conflicts at length. His claim was that the differences are best understood as differing ways in which different cultures have conceived and experienced one ultimate divine Reality, so that each major religious perspective "constitutes a valid context of salvation/liberation; but none constitutes the one and only such context."⁷¹

Two arguments are offered for it. The first is from what the witness calls transformation parity: an efficacious salvific process turns people from self-enclosure toward responsible participation in a larger reality, and "all the evidence we have," Hick maintains, shows that many religions are equally transformational on any general standard one cares to adopt. The second is epistemological: we have become "irreversibly aware" that there is no one universal and invariable pattern for interpreting human experience, but rather significantly different conceptual schemes "which have developed within the major cultural streams"—and once that is granted, "a pluralistic theory becomes inevitable."⁷²

The architecture, once one sees it, is Kant's—and this is the reason the pluralist section belongs in this article rather than in a different one. The discussion in this area is conducted, on the witness's own showing, in terms of a distinction between a pre-Kantian understanding of religious belief, on which we have or could have access to the truth as it is, and a Kantian understanding, on which "although there is a literal noumenal reality, our understanding of this reality ... will of necessity be relative to the cultural/social/psychological lenses through which our conceptualization of this noumenal reality is processed."⁷³ That is the same move made in the genealogy above, transposed from morality to metaphysics. Kant put the historical particular outside the essential because only the *a priori* binds all; the pluralist puts every particular tradition outside the ultimate because only the unconceptualized Real is the same for all. In both cases the particular is retained with respect, assigned a pedagogical function, and denied finality. The husk has become a lens, and the argument is otherwise unchanged.

7.3 What the hypothesis costs

The difficulties are well known and the witness records several of them: that transformation parity is hard to establish objectively; that comparable transformation is observable in people who commit themselves to non-religious causes, which would suggest the change is a general feature of self-transcending commitment rather than evidence of contact with a divine reality; that the selection of which traditions count as valid paths turns out to require substantive moral criteria smuggled in from somewhere; and that a religious exclusivist may reasonably decline to grant that the pluralist's account of cultural conditioning defeats his own background beliefs.⁷⁴

To those this article adds one that follows from everything above. The pluralist hypothesis is not neutral among the traditions; it is a substantive theological position that contradicts most of them, and it contradicts them at precisely

the point where they are most themselves. A Jew who believes that God spoke at Sinai, a Muslim who believes the Qur'an was sent down, a Christian who believes the Word was made flesh—each is told that what he means by his central claim is not what he means by it, but a culturally conditioned representation of an unconditioned Real about which no tradition's central claim can be literally true. That is not a view from above the traditions. It is one more particular view, held by particular people in a particular century, that has the interesting property of being the only one on the table permitted to describe how things actually are. Celsus's superintending spirits had the same structure: a serene higher standpoint from which every local cult is valid precisely because none of them is telling the truth about the whole.

There is a further cost, and it bears directly on this article's subject. The pluralist hypothesis secures universality by evacuating particularity—and it thereby throws away the one thing that made the traditions worth comparing. If no tradition's concrete claims can be finally true, then what the traditions offer is not knowledge of God but responses to an unknown, and the "Reality" toward which they are said to point is by construction one about which nothing determinate can be said. A God who is compatible with every description because no description reaches him is not more universal than the God of the Christian creed. He is less: he is a limit, not an agent, and one may not pray to a limit. The move that was meant to honor everyone's God ends by leaving no one's God able to act.

7.4 The magisterial answer

The Catholic Church addressed this position formally in the year 2000, in the declaration *Dominus Iesus* of the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, and the document is worth quoting rather than paraphrased, because its formulations are careful and its concessions are real.

It names the target precisely: "The Church's constant missionary proclamation is endangered today by relativistic theories which seek to justify religious pluralism, not only de facto but also de iure (or in principle)." Among the presuppositions it identifies behind such theories are "the conviction of the elusiveness and inexpressibility of divine truth, even by Christian revelation"; "relativistic attitudes toward truth itself, according to which what is true for some would not be true for others"; "the difficulty in understanding and accepting the presence of definitive and eschatological events in history"; and—the phrase that most exactly names the objection this whole article has been answering—"the metaphysical emptying of the historical incarnation of the Eternal Logos, reduced to a mere appearing of God in history."⁷⁵

The declaration then states the thesis it rejects, and states it fairly. "In contemporary theological reflection there often emerges an approach to Jesus of Nazareth that considers him a particular, finite, historical figure, who reveals the divine not in an exclusive way, but in a way complementary with other revelatory and salvific figures. The Infinite, the Absolute, the Ultimate Mystery of God would thus manifest itself to humanity in many ways and in many historical figures: Jesus of Nazareth would be one of these."⁷⁶ That is the objection of these pages in its exact contemporary dress, and the words "particular, finite, historical" are doing the same work they did for Celsus.

The answer given is the one this article has been arguing on other grounds. The theory "of the limited, incomplete, or imperfect character of the revelation of Jesus Christ, which would be complementary to that found in other religions, is contrary to the Church's faith"—because "the words, deeds, and entire historical event of Jesus, though limited as human realities, have nevertheless the divine Person of the Incarnate Word . . . as their subject." Hence "the truth about God is not abolished or reduced because it is spoken in human language; rather, it is unique, full, and complete, because he who speaks and acts is the Incarnate Son of God."⁷⁷

Two features of the declaration deserve notice, because they are commonly missed by both its admirers and its critics.

The first is what it concedes. It quotes the Council's teaching that the Church "rejects nothing of what is true and holy in these religions," and that their precepts and teachings "often reflect a ray of that truth which enlightens all men"; it affirms that "the various religious traditions contain and offer religious elements which come from God"; it allows that "some prayers and rituals of the other religions may assume a role of preparation for the Gospel." It also insists that whatever superiority belongs to Christians is not theirs: "all the children of the Church should nevertheless remember that their exalted condition results, not from their own merits, but from the grace of Christ. If they fail to respond in thought, word, and deed to that grace, not only shall they not be saved, but they shall be more severely judged."⁷⁸ That last clause is the same logic Amos applied to Israel: election incriminates rather than exempts.

The second is what it refuses. It refuses to purchase peace by making the central claim vaguer. "Not infrequently it is proposed that theology should avoid the use of terms like 'unicity', 'universality', and 'absoluteness', which give the

impression of excessive emphasis on the significance and value of the salvific event of Jesus Christ in relation to other religions”; and the answer is that “such language is simply being faithful to revelation.” One “can and must say that Jesus Christ has a significance and a value for the human race and its history, which are unique and singular, proper to him alone, exclusive, universal, and absolute.”⁷⁹

Read those adjectives together—“unique and singular . . . universal, and absolute”—and one has this article’s thesis in a magisterial formula. They are not in tension. The singularity is not a limitation on the universality that some later theology may hope to file away; it is what the universality is made of. Set beside the pluralist proposal, the difference is not that one side is generous and the other narrow. It is that one side purchases universality by subtracting the particular, and the other holds that subtracting the particular leaves nothing universal behind.

7.5 What the answer does not claim

It is worth stating, before this section closes, exactly how much of the pluralist’s data the foregoing accepts.

It accepts that people outside the visible Church live holy lives, because the Church teaches it. It accepts that other traditions contain what is true and holy, because the Council said so. It accepts that human understanding is culturally conditioned, because that is simply the doctrine of abstraction from the metaphysical section, seen from the sociological side: finite knowers work with the concepts their situation supplies. It accepts that no one may be presumed lost, and it makes no claim whatever about the destiny of any individual. And it accepts that the manner in which grace reaches those who are not formally members of the Church is, in the Council’s own careful phrase, known to God rather than to us.⁸⁰

What it declines is the inference. From the fact that God’s grace is not confined to those who have heard, it does not follow that what they would hear is only one option among several. From the fact that our concepts are conditioned, it does not follow that nothing determinate has been said to us. And from the fact that the traditions differ, it does not follow that the differences are decorative. That last inference is the one the pluralist needs and cannot have, because it is not a discovery about the traditions. It is, like Spinoza’s, a corollary of a prior decision about what God can be—and the whole of this article has been an argument that the decision is wrong.

8 A Name Which No Man Knoweth

The risen Christ of the Gospels is, if anything, more stubbornly particular than the crucified one. The Easter narratives could easily have dissolved him into radiance; instead John shows him on a beach at dawn, having made breakfast: “they saw hot coals lying, and a fish laid thereon, and bread.” The glorified Lord of the universe has cooked. And the restoration of the apostle who denied him is not conducted by general amnesty but by name, in a thrice-repeated question aimed at one man’s specific wound: “Simon son of John, lovest thou me more than these?”⁸¹ Whatever resurrection means, it does not mean graduation from particularity. It means particularity made permanent.

This is the point at which the objection’s deepest premise can finally be named. Behind the preference for the universal over the particular lies a picture of perfection as generality—as if the best love were the widest, the way the best law is the widest. But love does not behave like law. Nobody wants to be loved in general. To be loved as an instance—of humanity, of womankind, of the deserving poor—is precisely not to be loved; the beloved wants to be seen and wanted as irreplaceably *this* one, and knows instantly the difference between a form letter and a letter. The objector’s God, who deals only in universals, could never love in the second way. He could only apply. The scandal of particularity, followed to its end, is the claim that God loves the way lovers love and not the way statutes apply—that the universal cause, who alone knows every singular directly, is thereby the only one for whom *everyone* can be a particular, no one an instance, no one an average.

It is worth pausing on how thoroughly this reverses the objection’s charge of provincialism. The objectors supposed that a God who says one name has thereby failed to say the others—as though divine attention were a finite resource, so that a gift here is a withholding there. That is true of us. It is not true of the one whose knowledge, on the classical account, reaches each singular directly because his causality does. For such a knower there is no economy of attention to be rationed and no queue to be worked through. The choice is not between the many and the one; it is between an address that can be made and a generality that cannot. Israel’s objection to Christian universalism and the Greek objection to Jewish election were, in this respect, the same objection, and both were answered in the same way: not by widening the address until it dissolved, but by keeping it and sending it out.

That is why the promise held out at the end of the New Testament to each of the redeemed is not absorption into a general beatitude but a keepsake of unrepeatable address: “To him that overcometh, I will give the hidden manna, and will give him a white counter, and in the counter, a new name written, which no man knoweth, but he that receiveth it.”⁸² A name no one else can know is the exact opposite of an abstraction. It is particularity perfected: identity so fully affirmed that it becomes a secret between two. And note what it is not. It is not a rank, which would place the holder on a scale with others; nor a title, which could in principle be transferred; nor a description, which could be satisfied by someone else. It is the one kind of word that cannot be generalized without ceasing to be what it is.

The argument of this article can now be stated in the order in which it was earned. Nothing exists except particulars, so a God who acts must act among them. Abstraction is the finite knower’s economy, not the infinite knower’s grandeur, so a God of generalities-only would be less than the classical God, not more. Individuality is not a defect in a nature but what a nature has when it actually is, and the summit of created being is not a nature at all but a subsistent individual—someone. Election, on its own documents, is the choice of one for the sake of all, announced with its own gratuity and its outward term in the same sentence. The Incarnation could not have been general without being nothing, and its one assumed body is the ground on which the Son is united in some fashion with every man. The sacraments prolong the same style, because a wound that is concrete is healed concretely, and the sign that carries the healing is word joined to matter in deliberate imitation of the Word joined to flesh. The newest form of the objection secures its universality by emptying the particular, and finds at the end that it has nothing determinate left to be universal about. And the end of the whole economy is not the dissolving of persons into the universal but the white stone: each one named, none interchangeable.

The scandal of particularity is real, and it is not a flaw to be explained away. It is the signature. He was always going to be somebody’s neighbor, from some town, with a known mother; and the question he asked there is still in force, still addressed—like everything else in this economy—to one person at a time.

Notes

¹Matthew 13:55–57, quoted from the Douay–Rheims translation (Challoner revision), a public-domain English witness; wording checked at the online text of the Douay–Rheims Bible, 24 July 2026 and re-checked 25 July 2026. The same episode appears in Mark 6:1–6. Scripture quotations throughout are brief and taken from this witness unless another is identified.

²Mark 6:3–5, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The printed witness carries a note on “he could not,” glossing it as unwillingness rather than incapacity; the annotation belongs to that edition, not to this article, and the exegetical question is not adjudicated here. Nothing in the argument depends on how the clause is resolved.

³John 1:45–46, Douay–Rheims. Philip’s answer—“Come and see”—is the Gospel’s own procedure for the question and is deliberately not an argument.

⁴1 Corinthians 1:22–25, Douay–Rheims. The Greek *skandalon* underlying “stumblingblock” is the root of the theological phrase. “Scandal of particularity” itself is a modern term of art in theology and biblical studies, not a scriptural or magisterial formula; this article uses it as a received label for the objection, not as a doctrinal category.

⁵Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.23, in the public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers English translation (Frederick Crombie), checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026; the full chapter re-read at the same witness 25 July 2026, from which the fuller quotation above is taken. Celsus’s words survive only as quoted by Origen; the attribution is therefore to Celsus as reported, which is how the ancient text itself presents it.

⁶*Contra Celsum* IV.99, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. The chapter states Celsus’s own positive doctrine of providence, quoted by Origen before being answered; Origen’s reply—that God cares “not, as Celsus supposes, merely of the whole, but beyond the whole, in a special degree of every rational being”—is taken up in the next section of this article.

⁷*Contra Celsum* V.25–26, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. Origen’s counter-question at V.26—who distributed the quarters of the earth among the superintendents, and by whose authority—is his own; it is noted here because it identifies the structural weakness the article later exploits, that a pluralism of superintendents still requires a superintendent of superintendents.

⁸*Contra Celsum* V.41, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. The final clause argues from the visible fortunes of the Jewish people and their land—from the manifest failure of election to look like preferment—a form the objection has never stopped taking. Origen’s summary at V.42 states the charge as “falsely giving themselves out as the chosen portion of the Supreme God above all other nations.” The passage is quoted here to state the objection at strength; it also carries the ancient polemic’s contempt, which is reported and not endorsed.

⁹*Contra Celsum* VI.78, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. Origen’s answer at VI.78–79 is discussed in the Incarnation section below.

¹⁰*Contra Celsum* IV.3 and IV.14, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. Origen’s replies at IV.5 and IV.14–15—that the Word “does not give His place or vacate His own seat, so that one place should be empty of Him, and another which did not formerly contain Him be filled,” and that the condescension proceeds “by the economy of His providence” with the divine essence unchanged—anticipate by a century and a half the Athanasian argument quoted later in this article.

¹¹Spinoza, *Tractatus theologico-politicus* (1670), ch. 3, in R. H. M. Elwes’s public-domain English translation (1883), checked at the Project Gutenberg edition, 24 July 2026; the whole chapter re-read at the same witness 25 July 2026, from which the additional quotations in this subsection are taken. Spinoza’s identification of God with the immanent order of nature is his own system’s premise, not a shared assumption of this article; the quotations are used to state the objection, not to concede its metaphysics.

¹²The essay’s occasion, addressee, and publication history are taken from Franz Muncker’s editorial apparatus in Karl Lachmann’s *Sämtliche Schriften*, 3rd ed., vol. 13 (Stuttgart, 1897), consulted 25 July 2026 in the Bavarian State Library scan at the Internet Archive: the sixteen-page open letter answered Johann Daniel Schumann’s *Über die Evidenz der Beweise für die Wahrheit der christlichen Religion*, published in September 1777; it was issued by the Fürstliche Waisenhausbuchhandlung at Brunswick in October or November 1777, with neither author nor publisher named on the title page, and was reprinted almost unchanged in the fifth part of the Berlin *Sämtliche Schriften* of 1791, pp. 115–128. Muncker records that for textual criticism only the first edition of 1777 comes into consideration. The characterization of the argument in this paragraph is the present article’s summary of the essay’s own course as printed in that edition, not a quotation of Lessing.

¹³G. E. Lessing, *Über den Beweis des Geistes und der Kraft. An den Herrn Director Schumann, zu Hannover* (Brunswick, 1777), quoted from the text printed in Lachmann–Muncker, *Sämtliche Schriften*, 3rd ed., vol. 13 (Stuttgart, 1897), at pp. 5 and 7, read 25 July 2026 in the Bavarian State Library scan at the Internet Archive. That edition prints the first sentence in its eighteenth-century orthography and with the lead-in retained above, where modern transcriptions normalize *nothwendigen* to *notwendigen*; the form quoted here is the edition’s. The English renderings in the text are the present article’s own working translations and are labeled as such, no public-domain English translation having been identified. The 1777 Brunswick first

printing, which Muncker names as the only textually authoritative witness, was not itself inspected: attempts on 24 and 25 July 2026 at zeno.org, projekt-gutenberg.org, de.wikisource.org, textlog.de, gutenberg.spiegel.de, and a Deutsches Textarchiv corpus search all failed or returned no hit. That remaining limit is recorded in the terminal appendix and the research record.

¹⁴Immanuel Kant, *Religion within the Boundary of Pure Reason*, book III, in J. W. Semple’s public-domain English translation (Edinburgh: Thomas Clark, 1838), at pp. 132–133 of that printing; wording checked 25 July 2026 in the full-text scan of the 1838 edition at the Internet Archive. Semple’s rendering is free, and the emphatic capitalization is the printing’s own, retained here; it is used as an identified public-domain working witness, not as a critical translation, and Kant’s German governs any wording-critical claim. This article has not collated the German, and makes no claim finer than the argumentative structure quoted.

¹⁵Kant, *Religion*, book III, Semple translation (1838), at pp. 148–151; checked 25 July 2026 at the same Internet Archive scan. The governing question of the book’s third part is stated there in exactly these terms: “whether the ecclesiastical faith is not, as a mere vehicle, destined ultimately to pass—distant, indeed, though the day be—into a pure a priori belief in religious matters.”

¹⁶Kant, *Religion*, book IV, Semple translation (1838), at p. 224; checked 25 July 2026 at the same scan. Semple renders *Wahn* as “delusion” and glosses it in a footnote as “imagination, whimsey, conceit, or fancy.” It should be recorded that a note in the same book characterizes Judaism, Islam, and Hindu religion in terms this article neither reproduces nor endorses; what is engaged here is the argument about statutory versus rational faith, and no part of Kant’s comparative ethnography is used.

¹⁷Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 4, a. 4, corpus, in the public-domain English Dominican translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026. Aquinas is there rejecting both the Platonist subsistent universal and the suggestion that the Word could have assumed human nature “abstracted from all individuals.” The moderate-realist account of universals adopted in this section is a school position argued by the article, not a dogma; the article’s later theological claims do not stand or fall with its technical formulation.

¹⁸Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 29, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. The scholastic tag for the clause quoted is *actiones sunt singularium*; it is mentioned here as the received label for the doctrine, not as a separately collated quotation.

¹⁹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 86, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026. The claim concerns direct intellectual knowledge of *material* singulars and includes Aquinas’s account of indirect knowledge by reflection on phantasms; it is not a denial that human beings know individuals at all.

²⁰Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 14, a. 11, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

²¹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 22, a. 2, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026. Aquinas’s account of providence includes real secondary causes and divine permission; nothing here licenses reading particular sufferings as particular punishments.

²²Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.99, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. Origen’s argument in the surrounding chapters that the world was made for the sake of rational creatures is his own, engages Stoic and Platonist cosmology, and is not adopted here; what is taken from the passage is only the distinction between care for the whole and care for each, which is the point at issue.

²³Thomas Aquinas, *De ente et essentia*, in the chapter treating essence in composite substances—ch. 2 in the common division, printed as ch. 1 of the treatise proper at the Corpus Thomisticum, which sets the prooemium apart and renumbers accordingly. Latin checked at the Corpus Thomisticum text, 25 July 2026: “materia non quolibet modo accepta est individuationis principium, sed solum materia signata. Et dico materiam signatam, quae sub determinatis dimensionibus consideratur . . . In diffinitione autem hominis ponitur materia non signata; non enim in diffinitione hominis ponitur hoc os et haec caro, sed os et caro absolute.” The English here and in the next sentence is this article’s own labeled working translation; no public-domain English translation of the treatise was identified for this study. The chapter-numbering divergence is recorded so that either edition can be checked.

²⁴Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 29, a. 1, objection 1 with its reply, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The reply concedes that “this or that singular may not be definable” while holding that what belongs to the general idea of singularity can be defined. The concession is the point relied on here; the full reply is not being reduced to it.

²⁵Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 50, a. 4, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The angelology is a school position contested in the schools—Scotus, among others, rejected it—and nothing in this article’s theological claims depends on it. It is cited because it shows the individuation doctrine being applied consistently where the application costs something, which is a mark of a principle held rather than assumed.

²⁶Reported at a stated secondary-witness ceiling from Thomas Williams, “John Duns Scotus,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (first published 31 May 2001; substantive revision 15 December 2025), checked 25 July 2026, which supplies the account summarized here and identifies the primary locus as *Ordinatio* II, d. 3, pars 1, qq. 1–6. Scotus’s text was not collated for this article, no Scotist wording is quoted anywhere in it, and no claim finer than the summary given—common nature, contraction, haecceity as a positive individuating principle—is made. The Thomist–Scotist dispute over individuation is not adjudicated here.

²⁷Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 29, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The definition under discussion is Boethius’s—“an individual substance of a rational nature”—and Aquinas’s argument is an exposition of why each of its terms is required.

²⁸Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 29, a. 3, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The article asks whether “person” may be said of God, and answers that it may, since “everything that is perfect must be attributed to God,” though “not, however, as it is applied to creatures, but in a more excellent way.” That analogical qualification is essential and is preserved throughout this article: nothing here predicates individuality of God univocally with creatures, and the article’s own terminology section restates the limit.

²⁹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 8, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The third reply of the same article—“it belongs to the great power of God that He acts immediately in all things. Hence nothing is distant from Him”—bears directly on the objection’s picture of a remote God dealing in generalities. The presence asserted is that of causal immediacy, not of composition; Aquinas denies composition expressly at I, q. 3, a. 8, cited above.

³⁰The essence–existence distinction, participated *esse*, and the analogical predication of creaturely perfections of God are argued in the companion studies of this collection—particularly the first part of *The Creature Before God*—and are not re-argued here. This article borrows only the consequence stated in the text: that what a creature most fundamentally receives is its act of being, and that this act is received by an individual. Readers who reject the participation framework can still take the present section’s argument in its weaker form, which needs only that abstraction is a finite knower’s device and that action terminates in singulars.

³¹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, a. 5 (God is not in a genus) and a. 8 (God does not enter into composition with things), English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

³²Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.5, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. Origen appeals to Jeremiah’s “Do I not fill heaven and earth?” and to Paul’s Areopagus speech. What the passage settles is only the coherence question—that presence in a particular need not be desertion of the whole. The properly Christological questions raised by the Incarnation are not settled by it and are treated at their own place below.

³³Genesis 12:1–3, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The printed witness sets “in thee” in capitals as house emphasis; the wording is unaltered and the case normalized.

³⁴Genesis 17:4–7, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The printed witness carries an annotation on the Hebrew sense of the two names (“a high father”; “the father of the multitude”); the etymology is the edition’s, and the article relies only on the text’s own explicit gloss, “a father of many nations,” which the verse supplies in the same breath as the renaming.

³⁵Genesis 25:23, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The oracle is given to Rebecca before the birth. The article cites it for the pattern—choice antecedent to merit—and does not enter the long exegetical and dogmatic discussion of election and reprobation that Paul’s use of the verse at Romans 9 opened, which lies outside its scope.

³⁶Genesis 28:13–14, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026; the printed witness again sets parts of the blessing formula in capitals as house emphasis, normalized here without alteration of wording. The repetition of the Genesis 12 formula at each generation of the patriarchal narrative is the text’s own device, not this article’s construction.

³⁷Deuteronomy 7:6–8, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026 and re-read in its chapter context 25 July 2026. The passage grounds election solely in God’s love and fidelity to the patriarchal oath, and expressly excludes national greatness as a ground. It must be recorded that the same chapter opens (7:1–5) with the command to destroy the peoples of Canaan and their cult objects, a text that raises serious historical, exegetical, and moral questions which this article does not treat and does not need for its argument; the citation is confined to the ground of election stated in vv. 6–8, and no endorsement of the surrounding commands is expressed or implied.

³⁸Deuteronomy 10:14–15, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The rhetorical structure—universal ownership asserted, then particular choice asserted with an adversative—is the text’s own; the article’s reading of that structure as a deliberate juxtaposition is interpretation and is labeled as such in the terminal appendix.

³⁹Deuteronomy 10:17–19, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The inference runs from God’s impartiality and care for the resident alien to Israel’s obligation toward the alien, grounded in Israel’s own remembered condition. The article cites it as the chapter’s own drawing-out of election’s ethical consequence; the extensive legal material on the *ger* elsewhere in the Pentateuch is outside scope.

⁴⁰Amos 9:7, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026 and re-read with its immediate context 25 July 2026. The printed witness carries an annotation on “the children of the Ethiopians” which the article does not adopt. God’s providential involvement in other nations’ migrations is asserted by the prophet himself; it is not a modern gloss.

⁴¹Amos 9:8, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The oracle’s structure—universal providence asserted, presumption rebuked, remnant preserved—is the passage’s own. This article does not adjudicate the composition history of Amos 9 or the relation of vv. 11–15 to what precedes.

⁴²Isaiah 49:1, 6, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026 and re-read in its chapter context 25 July 2026. The identity of the Servant is a classical exegetical question—Israel corporately (the chapter itself says at v. 3, “Thou art my servant Israel”), the

prophet, the Messiah—which this article does not adjudicate; the cited point, that election is ordered to universal salvation, holds on any of the main readings. Verse 7’s address “to the soul that is despised, to the nation that is abhorred” is noted for the same reason as the Celsus passage above: the texts themselves know that election has not looked like preferment.

⁴³John 1:14, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026.

⁴⁴Galatians 4:4–5 and Luke 2:1–2, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The article cites the census as Luke’s deliberate anchoring of the nativity in datable public administration; the well-known historical questions about the Quirinius enrollment’s date are outside its scope and are not adjudicated here.

⁴⁵Luke 3:1–2, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. Six named office-holders, imperial, provincial, tetrarchal, and priestly, are stacked before the sentence reaches its subject. The historical questions raised by the synchronism—including the reckoning of Tiberius’s fifteenth year and the joint mention of Annas and Caiaphas—are outside this article’s scope.

⁴⁶Matthew 1:1–16, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. Matthew’s own arrangement into three sets of fourteen, and the textual and historical questions raised by the list’s relation to the Old Testament genealogies and to Luke’s, are outside this article’s scope; the article’s claim concerns only the fact and direction of the two lists, which are visible on any reading.

⁴⁷Matthew 1:3, 5, 6, 10–11, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The four women, the naming of David’s adultery by circumlocution, and the double marking of the transmigration of Babylon are features of the text as it stands. The considerable exegetical literature on why Matthew includes these women is not surveyed here, and the reading offered in the following sentence—that the list refuses to launder the line—is this article’s own and is labeled as synthesis in the terminal appendix.

⁴⁸Luke 3:23–38, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026; the terminal clause quoted is v. 38. Luke’s genealogy differs from Matthew’s in position, direction, and content, and the harmonization of the two is a long-standing exegetical question that this article neither enters nor needs.

⁴⁹Athanasius, *De incarnatione Verbi* 8 and 17, in Archibald Robertson’s public-domain translation (Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, second series, vol. 4), checked 24 July 2026 in a full-text copy of the NPNF edition. Section 17 is the classical statement of what later theology discussed as the *extra*: the incarnate Word’s continuing cosmic presence and activity.

⁵⁰Athanasius, *De incarnatione Verbi* 42–43, Robertson translation, checked 24 July 2026. The quoted objection is Athanasius’s own statement of his adversaries’ question; “He takes to Himself as an instrument a part of the whole, His human body,” *ibid.* 43, gives the positive principle: known in the part because unrecognized in the whole.

⁵¹Origen, *Contra Celsum* VI.78–79, Crombie translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 25 July 2026. Origen adds, at VI.79, that those who desire to see “many bodies filled with a divine Spirit” should look to the preachers of the Gospel in all lands, whom Scripture terms anointed; the article notes the move because it turns the demand for simultaneity into an account of mission, which is where the following sections take it.

⁵²Irenaeus, *Adversus haereses* III.22.1–2 and V, preface, in the public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation (Roberts and Rambaut), checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026.

⁵³Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 4, a. 4, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

⁵⁴Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 4, a. 5, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

⁵⁵Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 1, a. 1, corpus; English wording from the Dominican translation, Latin checked in the Corpus Thomisticum text, 24 July 2026. Arguments from fittingness (*convenientia*) show harmony, not necessity: they answer “why is this worthy of God?” rather than “why must this have happened?”—and this article uses them only in that role.

⁵⁶*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1085, official English text, checked at the Vatican website, 24 July 2026. The paragraph’s own claim—that the Paschal mystery, unlike every other historical event, “cannot remain only in the past”—is taken up in the following section.

⁵⁷Second Vatican Council, *Gaudium et spes* 22, official English translation at the Vatican website, checked 24 July 2026. The paragraph’s universality claim is the council’s own; its precise theological modality (“in some fashion,” *quodammodo*) is preserved and not inflated here.

⁵⁸1 Corinthians 1:25, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026.

⁵⁹Leo the Great, *Sermo* 74 (De ascensione Domini II), 2, in the public-domain Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers translation (Charles Lett Feltoe), checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026.

⁶⁰*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1084–1085, official English text at the Vatican website, checked 24 July 2026. This is a claim of sacramental making-present, not of repetition: the historical event is not reenacted but its saving power made available. The article does not expand here into a treatise on sacramental validity, matter and form, or the theology of Eucharistic presence, all of which have their own governing sources.

⁶¹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 60, a. 2, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The article is defining a sacrament as “the sign of a holy thing so far as it makes men holy,” and the clause quoted supplies the anthropological premise on which the rest of the question turns.

⁶²Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 60, aa. 4–5, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026 and re-read 25 July 2026. Article 4’s *sed contra* appeals to Wisdom 8:1 and to Dionysius; article 5’s argument is that determining the means of another’s act belongs to that other. The determinacy point matters to this article’s argument and is why it is quoted: an economy of instituted signs is more particular, not less, than an economy of natural symbols.

⁶³Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 60, a. 6, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. Aquinas gives three reasons for the addition of words; only the first, the conformity to the Incarnation, is used here. The second—that the remedy is fitted to a creature composed of soul and body, “since it touches the body through the sensible element, and the soul through faith in the words”—bears on the following paragraph.

⁶⁴Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 61, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. The third reason—that bodily exercise in the sacraments displaces harmful and superstitious practice—is Aquinas’s own and is not relied on here. Aquinas’s reply to the second objection states the boundary this article observes: “God’s grace is a sufficient cause of man’s salvation. But God gives grace to man in a way which is suitable to him.”

⁶⁵*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1145–1149, official English text, checked at the Vatican website, 25 July 2026. The concession at 1149 is the Catechism’s own and is quoted here because a fair statement of the Catholic position must include it; the same paragraph adds that the Church’s liturgy “presupposes, integrates and sanctifies elements from creation and human culture, conferring on them the dignity of signs of grace.” The relation of the Church to other religions is treated at its own place below and under its own governing documents.

⁶⁶*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1150, official English text, checked 25 July 2026. The typological reading that follows in the same paragraph—that the Church sees in these signs “a prefiguring of the sacraments of the New Covenant”—is the Catechism’s own and is reported, not independently argued.

⁶⁷*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1151–1152, official English text, checked 25 July 2026.

⁶⁸Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 75, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. Aquinas gives three reasons; the article quotes the second. The first (the perfection of the New Law over against the figures of the Old) and the third (the perfection of faith, “since faith is of things unseen”) are noted but not relied on. This article states the doctrine of the real presence as the Church’s teaching and does not undertake its exposition or defense; sacramental theology proper, including transubstantiation and the conditions of validity, is outside its scope, as its terminal appendix records.

⁶⁹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 76, a. 3, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 25 July 2026. Aquinas rejects, in the same corpus, the mirror analogy sometimes offered for this, on the ground that the comparison is imperfect. The metaphysics of substance and quantity presupposed here belongs to the sacramental theology this article does not undertake; the point taken is only the formal one stated in the following sentence.

⁷⁰Ephesians 4:4–6, Douay–Rheims, checked 25 July 2026. The article cites the passage for the juxtaposition it makes—a series of determinate singulars terminating in the Father of all—and does not enter the ecclesiological questions about the unity of the Church that the passage has been used to argue, which are governed by their own sources.

⁷¹Reported at a stated secondary-witness ceiling from David Basinger, “Religious Diversity (Pluralism),” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (first published 25 May 2004; substantive revision 21 February 2025), checked 25 July 2026, which supplies the summary given here and prints the quoted phrases with attributions to Hick 1983, p. 487 and Hick 1984, pp. 229, 231. Hick’s own books and articles were not collated for this study; no claim about his position finer than this witness supports is made anywhere in this article, and the quoted phrases are quoted as that witness prints them.

⁷²Same witness, checked 25 July 2026; the quoted phrases are printed there with attribution to Hick 2004, ch. 3, and Hick 1984, p. 232. The same entry records the standing objections to both arguments, several of which are noted below with attribution to the witness rather than to this article.

⁷³Same witness, checked 25 July 2026, where the distinction is set out and attributed to Philip Quinn (Quinn 2000, pp. 241–242) in the course of a discussion of Alston. The distinction is reported here as the shape of the contemporary debate, not attributed to Hick, whose own formulations were not collated. The genealogical observation drawn in the next paragraph—that the pluralist hypothesis stands in Kant’s line—is this article’s own and is labeled as synthesis in the terminal appendix.

⁷⁴All four objections are reported from Basinger, “Religious Diversity (Pluralism),” checked 25 July 2026, which sets them out in the course of expounding Hick’s position and attributes several to named critics (Clark 1997 for the secular-transformation parallel; the discussion of criteria referring to Hick 1997b, p. 164). They are reported here, not originated; the paragraph that follows is this article’s own argument.

⁷⁵Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, declaration *Dominus Iesus* (6 August 2000), no. 4; official English text at the Vatican website, checked 25 July 2026. The declaration was approved and confirmed by John Paul II and ordered published; it is a dicasterial declaration reiterating doctrine taught elsewhere, and its authority is that of the documents it restates, on each of which it supplies references. This article cites it as the magisterial answer to the position described, not as a source for any independent claim.

⁷⁶*Dominus Iesus* 9, official English text, checked 25 July 2026. The paragraph continues with a second thesis—an economy of the eternal Word valid outside the Church and unrelated to her, in addition to an economy of the incarnate Word—which

no. 10 rejects on the ground that “it is likewise contrary to the Catholic faith to introduce a separation between the salvific action of the Word as such and that of the Word made man.”

⁷⁷ *Dominus Iesus* 6, official English text, checked 25 July 2026. The same paragraph preserves the qualification this article has been careful to keep: “even if the depth of the divine mystery in itself remains transcendent and inexhaustible.” Nothing here converts the completeness of the revelation given into a claim that the divine essence is comprehended.

⁷⁸ *Dominus Iesus* 2, 21, 22, official English text, checked 25 July 2026, quoting *Nostra aetate* 2 and *Lumen gentium* 14. The final sentence quoted at no. 22 is itself a citation of *Lumen gentium* 14. The declaration’s further teaching at nos. 20–22 on the necessity of the Church, on grace reaching those who are not formally her members, and on the gravely deficient situation of those lacking the fullness of the means of salvation is stated at those loci and is not summarized further here; this article makes no claim about the salvation of any individual, which it expressly excludes from its scope.

⁷⁹ *Dominus Iesus* 15, official English text, checked 25 July 2026. The same paragraph grounds the claim in the community’s recognition “from the beginning” of a salvific value in Jesus such that “he alone, as Son of God made man, crucified and risen . . . bestows revelation . . . and divine life . . . to all humanity and to every person.”

⁸⁰ *Dominus Iesus* 20–21, official English text, checked 25 July 2026, citing *Lumen gentium* 14 and 16 and *Ad gentes* 7, and recording that on the manner in which salvific grace comes to individual non-Christians the Second Vatican Council “limited itself to the statement that God bestows it ‘in ways known to himself,’” while adding that theologians’ work of understanding this more fully “is to be encouraged.” The Israel–Church relation, the theology of religions as a discipline, and the question of individual salvation are all outside this article’s scope, as its terminal appendix records.

⁸¹ John 21:9, 12, 15, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The threefold question answering the threefold denial is a classical reading of the passage’s structure, here used as reading rather than asserted as the evangelist’s stated intention.

⁸² Apocalypse (Revelation) 2:17, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The verse is quoted for its image of irreducibly personal address; no claim is made here about the disputed identification of the “white counter” (*calculus*, stone) in the history of exegesis.

A The Objection and Its Answers: A Synopsis

The table below is a navigational summary of the objection tradition engaged in this article, in chronological order, with the form each objector gives the argument and the place where the article answers it. It is editorial synthesis: every entry compresses a treatment given, with citations, verification dates, and qualifications, in the body, the Notes, and the References, which govern over this compression. “Reported” marks positions engaged at a stated secondary-witness ceiling rather than from collated primary text.

Objector	Century	Form of the objection	Where answered
The Nazareth congregation; Nathanael	1st	The native form: the known particular discredits the claim. “Is not this the carpenter’s son?”; “Can any thing of good come from Nazareth?” (Matt 13:55–57; Mark 6:3–5; John 1:46).	Not answered by argument but by the whole economy: the article’s thesis is that the definite articles are the signature, not the flaw (opening and closing sections).
Celsus (via Origen, <i>Contra Celsum</i>)	2nd	Providence attends the whole, not individuals (IV.99); national cults are locally valid under allotted superintendents (V.25–26); Jewish election improbable (V.41); descent entails change (IV.3, 14); one corner instead of many bodies is ridiculous (VI.78).	Providence over singulars and the non-topical descent (metaphysical section, with Origen’s own replies at IV.5 and IV.99); election as means of universality (election section); sufficiency of the one Word that propagates (Incarnation section, with <i>Contra Celsum</i> VI.78–79); the superintendent scheme’s regress and its return as modern pluralism (final objection section).
Spinoza, <i>Tractatus theologico-politicus</i> ch. 3	17th	God is the immutable order of nature, so election dissolves: all are elect, hence none; Israel’s vocation reduced to polity; blessedness defined as what is possessable by all without loss.	The distributability test cannot see address; a law says no one’s name; the accommodation principle is unfalsifiable and the texts already raise the difficulty themselves (election section).
Lessing, <i>Über den Beweis des Geistes und der Kraft</i>	18th	Accidental truths of history can never prove necessary truths of reason; the ugly broad ditch. (German quoted from the Lachmann–Muncker edition; working translations labeled.)	The inference is sound but the cargo is misidentified: the Gospel proposes healing, not demonstration, and the Paschal event reaches the present by presence rather than report (Incarnation and sacraments sections).
Kant, <i>Religion within the Boundary of Pure Reason</i> (Semple, 1838)	18th	Only one purely moral religion; historical faith valid only for those the history reaches, hence never binding on all; ecclesiastical faith a vehicle whose husk the rational kernel outgrows.	The reachability criterion governs obligations, not gifts; it would disqualify most received goods; the kernel was in fact extracted from the husk it proposes to discard (Incarnation section); the sacramental economy as the standing refusal of the retreat to concept (sacraments section).
Contemporary pluralism (Hick, reported via named SEP witness)	20th–21st	The traditions are culturally shaped responses to one ultimate Reality; each a valid context of salvation, none the only one; transformation parity; conceptual schemes make a pluralistic theory inevitable.	The hypothesis is itself one particular position that contradicts the traditions at their centers; it evacuates the determinacy it set out to honor; the reported standing objections (parity, secular parallel, smuggled criteria); the magisterial answer of <i>Dominus Iesus</i> 4, 6, 9–10, 15, 20–22 (final objection section).

B Scope, Method, and Qualifications

B.1 Reader, question, and claim boundary

This is a discursive article in faith and theology for an intellectually serious reader—Christian or considering the Christian claim—who can follow a metaphysical distinction but is not presumed to know scholastic terminology. Its governing question: does the concrete particularity of the biblical economy—one chosen people, one incarnate life, instituted material sacraments, personal address—degrade the universality proper to God, as a long objection tradition running from Celsus through Spinoza, Lessing, and Kant to contemporary religious pluralism contends? Its governing claim: the objection rests on a false premise that generality is the divine mode; in the classical account, only particulars exist concretely, abstraction is the finite knower’s limitation, individuality is a positive perfection whose summit in creation is the person, God knows and sustains every singular directly, and the biblical particulars are consistently ordered to universal scope—election for all nations, one assumed body grounding union with every human being, repeatable concrete signs carrying the once-for-all event outward.

The argument establishes coherence and fittingness, not occurrence. It does not prove the Incarnation or Resurrection from metaphysics, adjudicate among claimed revelations, resolve historical questions such as the Quirinius census date or the Lucan synchronisms, or supply the reader’s act of faith. Fittingness arguments (*convenientia*) are used only retrospectively: they show why an event believed on other grounds is worthy of God, never that it had to happen.

B.2 Terminology fixed for this article

- **Particular** means concrete, singular, historically located: this person, people, body, act, sign. It is predicated of creatures, divine actions, and the assumed humanity of Christ—never of God as though he were one member of a class.
- **Universal** is used in two senses kept explicit in the argument: the abstract universal (a common nature as object of thought) and the universal cause (God as giver of being to every creature). The article’s central distinction is that the second does not entail the first as a divine mode of relating to creatures.
- **Individuation** names whatever makes a particular the particular it is; the article expounds the Thomist answer (designated matter) and reports the Scotist answer (haecceity) without adjudicating between them.
- **Person** is used in Boethius’s sense as expounded by Aquinas (a subsistent individual of a rational nature), and is predicated of God only analogically, as the cited article itself requires.
- **Scandal of particularity** is a received modern label for the objection, not a scriptural or magisterial category.
- **Flight into abstraction** names the article’s diagnosis of the preference for a non-landing God; it is an editorial characterization, not a canonical classification of any thinker.
- **Election** means gratuitous divine choice conferring vocation and mission, expressly not antecedent merit or exclusive divine concern.
- **Pluralist hypothesis** means the position summarized at the reported ceiling in the contemporary section (one ultimate Reality, many equally valid culturally shaped responses); it is engaged as a philosophical-theological thesis, not as a description of any named person’s faith.

B.3 Source hierarchy and authority classes

Scripture governs the pattern claims (election’s gratuity and outward ordering through the patriarchal narrowing, the prophets’ universalism-through-particularity, the Incarnation and its genealogies, the risen Christ’s particularity, the Church’s one baptism); brief clauses are quoted from the public-domain Douay–Rheims (Challoner) translation as an identified working witness, without any claim that it is a critical text. Conciliar, catechetical, and dicasterial texts (*Gaudium et spes* 22; *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1084–1085 and 1145–1152; *Dominus Iesus* 2, 4, 6, 9–10, 13–15, 20–22) govern the universality of Christ’s union with humanity, the sacramental economy, and the answer to pluralism, each at its own authority level; *Dominus Iesus* is cited as a dicasterial declaration reiterating doctrine taught in the sources it cites. Patristic witnesses (Origen answering Celsus; Irenaeus; Athanasius; Leo) show that the particularity objection was met, not evaded, in the tradition; breadth of citation is illustrative, not an authority count.

Aquinas supplies the metaphysical framework (knowledge of singulars, providence over individuals, God outside every genus and innermost present to each thing, individuation by designated matter, the person as summit of created perfection, the individual term of the assumption, sensible and instituted signs, the sacraments' conformity to the Incarnation); these are school positions adopted and argued, not dogmas. Celsus (as quoted by Origen), Spinoza, Lessing, Kant, and the pluralist hypothesis are objection sources, quoted or reported to state the strongest opposing case, with their governing premises identified rather than conceded. Secondary encyclopedia witnesses (two named Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entries) are used only at stated reported ceilings. Everything else—the ordering of the argument, the inversion of the abstraction premise, the reading of the genealogies and of Deuteronomy 10's juxtaposition, the letter and doctor and form-letter analogies, the identification of the pluralist hypothesis's Kantian architecture, the reading of Rev 2:17 as particularity perfected—is project synthesis.

B.4 Material qualifications

1. God is not a particular alongside others; predicating choice, address, and personality of God does not place him in a genus (ST I, q. 3, a. 5 and I, q. 29, a. 3 are cited to that effect, the latter with its own analogical qualification preserved).
2. The moderate-realist account of universals, the Thomistic analysis of abstraction, and the doctrine of individuation by designated matter are adopted school positions; the Scotist alternative is reported at a named-witness ceiling and the dispute is not adjudicated; the theological claims of the later sections do not stand or fall with any one technical formulation.
3. The angelology of ST I, q. 50, a. 4 is cited only to show the individuation principle applied consistently; nothing depends on it.
4. The essence–existence distinction, participated being, and analogical predication are argued in companion studies of this collection and are borrowed here, not re-argued; the section using them states a weaker fallback for readers who reject the framework.
5. Divine knowledge of singulars and particular providence follow the classical Thomistic account; no inference is licensed from particular suffering to particular guilt.
6. Election's outward ordering does not by itself identify which claimed revelation is true; the article says so explicitly and argues coherence only. Israel's election remains, in Christian teaching, irrevocable; nothing here treats Israel as a discarded instrument, and the Israel–Church relation is not adjudicated. Deuteronomy 7 is cited for vv. 6–8 only; the surrounding herem commands raise questions outside this article's scope and receive no endorsement, express or implied.
7. Genesis 25:23 is cited for the pattern of choice antecedent to merit; the dogmatic questions opened by Romans 9's use of it are outside scope. The readings of Matthew's four women, of Luke's genealogy, and of Deuteronomy 10:14–15's juxtaposition are labeled interpretations.
8. Athanasius's cosmic-Word argument is directed *ad hominem* at interlocutors who granted the Word's presence in the whole; the hypostatic union differs in kind from the Word's union with creation, as the cited edition's own annotation notes. Origen's replies to Celsus are used for the two points quoted (providence beyond the whole; non-topical descent; the sufficiency of the one Word), not adopted wholesale.
9. “United Himself in some fashion with every man” retains the council's qualifier; universal salvific scope is not converted into a claim that all are in fact saved.
10. Sacramental making-present is not repetition of the historical event; the paragraphs on assurance do not reduce grace to mechanism or dispense with faith and disposition; sacramental validity, matter and form, and the exposition or defense of Eucharistic doctrine (including transubstantiation) are outside scope—ST III, qq. 75–76 are quoted for the fittingness reasons and the whole-in-each-part structure only, and the real presence is stated as the Church's teaching, not argued philosophically here.
11. The Lessing quotations are given in German from the Lachmann–Muncker *Sämtliche Schriften*, 3rd ed., vol. 13 (Stuttgart, 1897), pp. 5 and 7, in that edition's eighteenth-century orthography; the English renderings are the article's own labeled working translations, and no public-domain English translation was identified. The 1777 Brunswick first printing, which that edition's editor names as the only textually authoritative witness, was not itself inspected, and this remaining limit is recorded here and in the research record.

12. Kant is quoted from Semple’s 1838 public-domain translation as an identified working witness; the German was not collated, and no claim finer than the quoted argumentative structure is made. Kant’s comparative characterizations of other religions are expressly not reproduced or endorsed.
13. Hick and the surrounding debate are engaged entirely at a stated reported ceiling on a named SEP witness with its revision date; no Hick text was collated, and no claim about his position finer than that witness supports is made. The same holds for the Scotus material and its SEP witness.
14. *Dominus Iesus* is quoted exactly from the official English text at the Vatican website; its teaching on the situation of non-Christians is reported at its own loci without extension, and this article makes no claim about the salvation or standing of any individual or named community.
15. Celsus survives only in Origen’s quotation; attribution is to Celsus as reported, and the ancient polemic’s contempt for the Jewish people, where quoted to state the objection, is reported and rejected, not endorsed.
16. The closing section’s claims about love and the white stone are theological reading and synthesis, not exegetical assertions about authorial intention.

B.5 Coverage, currentness, translations, rights, and review

No liturgical rite, civil or canonical jurisdiction, or mutable discipline governs any conclusion; no legal claims are made. Online witnesses were checked on 24 July 2026 (first edition) and 25 July 2026 (deepened edition): Douay–Rheims chapter pages; New Advent transcriptions of the Ante-Nicene and Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers translations (including *Contra Celsum* books IV–VI) and of the English Dominican *Summa* (including I, qq. 8, 29, 50; III, qq. 60–61, 75–76); a full-text NPNF copy of Robertson’s Athanasius; the Corpus Thomisticum Latin for ST III, q. 1, a. 1 and for *De ente et essentia*; the Vatican website’s English *Catechism*, *Gaudium et spes*, and *Dominus Iesus*; the Project Gutenberg Elwes translation of Spinoza; the Internet Archive scans of Semple’s 1838 Kant and of Lachmann–Muncker’s Lessing, vol. 13; and the named Stanford Encyclopedia witnesses with their revision dates recorded. Quotations are brief and argument-driven. Scripture, official ecclesiastical texts, and third-party translations retain their own status and are not offered under the project’s CC BY 4.0 license; the Stanford Encyclopedia entries are used as checked secondary narratives and quoted only in short clauses with attribution. This is an internally source-audited working study by an AI-assisted process; the 25 July 2026 deepening (objection genealogy at depth with the Kant subsection, individuation and person material, expanded scriptural and sacramental sections, the contemporary pluralism section with *Dominus Iesus*, and the synopsis table) passed through the same audit; it has received no independent philosophical, biblical, patristic, dogmatic, literary, or ecclesiastical review and claims no ecclesiastical approval.

C References

Sacred Scripture

- Genesis 12:1–3; 17:4–7; 25:23; 28:13–14; Deuteronomy 7:6–8; 10:14–19; Isaiah 49:1–7; Amos 9:7–8; Matthew 1:1–16; 13:54–57; Mark 6:1–6; Luke 2:1–2; 3:1–2, 23–38; John 1:14, 45–46; 21:9–15; Galatians 4:4–5; Ephesians 4:4–6; 1 Corinthians 1:22–25; Apocalypse 2:17. Quoted from the public-domain Douay–Rheims translation (Challoner revision), checked at the online Douay–Rheims text, 24–25 July 2026. The translation is an identified working witness, not a critical edition.

Conciliar, catechetical, and dicasterial texts

- Second Vatican Council, pastoral constitution *Gaudium et spes* (7 December 1965), 22, on the Incarnation and the Son’s union “in some fashion with every man”; official English translation, vatican.va.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1084–1085 (Christ acting through perceptible sacramental signs; the Paschal mystery’s unique permanence) and 1145–1152 (signs of the human world, signs of the covenant, signs taken up by Christ, sacramental signs); official English text, vatican.va (1084–1085) and *ibid.* (1145–1152).
- Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, declaration *Dominus Iesus* on the unicity and salvific universality of Jesus Christ and the Church (6 August 2000), 2, 4, 6, 9–10, 13–15, 20–22; ratified and confirmed by John Paul II and ordered published; official English text, vatican.va.

Patristic witnesses

- Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.3–7, 14, 23, 99; V.25–26, 41–42; VI.78–79, preserving Celsus’s mockery of particular providence, his doctrine of the whole, his superintendent theory of national cults, his attack on Jewish election, and his one-corner objection, with Origen’s replies; Frederick Crombie’s public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation, Book IV, Book V, and Book VI at the New Advent transcription.
- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Adversus haereses* III.22.1–2 (real flesh from Mary) and V, preface (“become what we are”); Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut’s public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation, Book III witness and Book V preface.
- St. Athanasius of Alexandria, *De incarnatione Verbi* 8, 17, 41–43, on the assumed body, the uncircumscribed Word, and the reply to the “nobler instrument” objection; Archibald Robertson’s public-domain translation (NPNF, 2nd series, vol. 4), online witness; sections 41–43 verified in a full-text NPNF copy.
- St. Leo the Great, *Sermo* 74 (De ascensione II), 2, on the visible Redeemer passing into sacramental presence; Charles Lett Feltoe’s public-domain NPNF translation, online witness.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, aa. 5 and 8 (God in no genus, no composition); q. 8, a. 1 (God innermost in all things as giver of being); q. 14, a. 11 (knowledge of singulars); q. 22, a. 2 (providence over individuals); q. 29, aa. 1 and 3 (the person; “what is most perfect in all nature,” with its analogical qualification); q. 50, a. 4 (individuation applied to the angels); q. 86, a. 1 (the finite intellect and the singular); III, q. 1, a. 1 (fittingness of the Incarnation); q. 4, aa. 4–5 (the assumption’s individual term); q. 60, aa. 2, 4–6 (sensible, divinely determined signs; words joined to elements in conformity with the Incarnation); q. 61, a. 1 (the necessity of sacraments); q. 75, a. 1 and q. 76, a. 3 (fittingness of the real presence; the whole under every part).
- St. Thomas Aquinas, *De ente et essentia*, chapter on essence in composite substances (ch. 2 of the common division), on designated matter (*materia signata*) as the principle of individuation; Latin checked at the Corpus Thomisticum text; English renderings are the article’s own labeled working translations.
- English *Summa* loci checked in the public-domain English Dominican translation at the New Advent Summa; the Latin of III, q. 1, a. 1 checked at the Corpus Thomisticum. Work, part, question, and article take precedence over either site’s typesetting.

Objection tradition

- Baruch Spinoza, *Tractatus theologico-politicus* (1670), ch. 3, on the vocation of the Hebrews; R. H. M. Elwes’s public-domain English translation (1883), Project Gutenberg edition.
- Gotthold Ephraim Lessing, *Über den Beweis des Geistes und der Kraft. An den Herrn Director Schumann, zu Hannover* (Brunswick, 1777), on accidental truths of history and the “garstige breite Graben”; quoted from *Sämtliche Schriften*, ed. Karl Lachmann, 3rd ed. rev. Franz Muncker, vol. 13 (Stuttgart, 1897), pp. 5 and 7, with the occasion and publication history from Muncker’s editorial note at the head of the piece; Bavarian State Library scan at the Internet Archive. The 1777 first printing, which Muncker names as the only textually authoritative witness, was not inspected (see the research record); English renderings in the text are the article’s own labeled working translations.
- Immanuel Kant, *Die Religion innerhalb der Grenzen der bloßen Vernunft* (1793), quoted from *Religion within the Boundary of Pure Reason*, J. W. Semple’s public-domain English translation (Edinburgh: Thomas Clark, 1838), books III–IV; Internet Archive scan of the 1838 printing. The German was not collated; Semple is an identified working witness.
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Secondary witnesses at stated ceilings

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D Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-25T17:09:31Z

Model: claude-fable-5; **unexposed:** reasoning-effort and sampling configuration

Agent/runtime: Anthropic Claude Code agent (research, drafting, typesetting, review); Claude Code CLI 2.1.219; **unexposed:** server revision

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